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INBRIEF



Export-Import Bank of India donates retinal camera

The Export-Import Bank of India (Exim Bank) has donated a 3nethra Neo retinal camera to (Gurupriya Vision Research Foundation (GVRF), the charitable trust of Radhatri Nethralaya, to strengthen screening of preterm infants in rural areas. The device will be deployed under 'Project Vision on Wheels,' a teleophthalmology initiative that screens babies in villages for blinding conditions. A team led by general manager Dharmendra Sachan handed over the camera during a visit to the hospital. Praveen Krishna, trustee, GVRF and medical director, Radhatri Nethralaya, said the programme targets Retinopathy of Prematurity (ROP) among underprivileged families in rural Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh, with affected infants brought to Chennai for free treatment. Technicians travel up to 400 km for screenings. Vasumathy Vedantham, managing trustee, GVRF and medical director, Radhatri Nethralaya, were present.

Man arrested for throwing toilet acid on estranged wife

The Pallavaram police have arrested a 31-year-old man for throwing toilet acid on his estranged wife and causing serious eye injuries following a domestic quarrel. According to the police, the accused, Mohamed Ali, 31, of Kundrathur, had married the victim six years ago. The couple has a four-year-old daughter. Police said the couple had frequent disputes over the past year, reportedly due to Ali's alcohol addiction, and had recently separated with the consent of their families. The child remained with the mother, who moved to her parents' home in Pallavaram. Ali would visit on weekends to see the child. Investigators said the woman had been seeking a divorce, which the accused opposed. During an argument, he allegedly refused to agree to a divorce and accused her of being in an illicit relationship. As the quarrel escalated, Ali allegedly chased the woman on the street and threw toilet acid at her.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 18, Wednesday), the following articles are available:

- On scientific collaborations in BRICS newsth.live/zy7BIM
- Cholesterol makes cells' nuclei squishy, helping melanoma spread newsth.live/melanoma

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Dismissed policeman gets life imprisonment for raping minor girl

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

A Mahila Court has sentenced a dismissed police constable to imprisonment for the remainder of his natural life for raping a 16-year-old girl.

The accused made a false promise to marry her and later coerced her to abort her foetus, abetting her to end her life in 2020.

According to the prosecution, on November, 22, 2020, the mother of the victim lodged a complaint stating that her minor daughter was in a relationship with Magesh, 27, the police constable. As the complainant and her son had not accepted this relationship, her daughter ended her life. Consequently, M.K.B. Nagar Police registered an FIR for unnatural death.

Pursuant to the directions of the Madras High Court dated March 8, 2021, following a petition filed by the complainant who alleged foul play in the death, the investigation was transferred by then Director General of Police to the Crime Branch CID (CB-CID). The Anti-Trafficking Cell, CB-CID, re-registered the case and took up investigation.

At the conclusion of the trial, Mahila Court Judge G. Prabakaran pronounced the judgment convicting the dismissed constable Magesh and awarded rigorous life imprisonment for offence under Section 6 (Aggravated Penetrative Sexual Assault) of the POCSO Act which shall mean imprisonment for the remainder of his natural life. The Judge also sentenced him to undergo another life imprisonment for abetment of suicide.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, Tele-MANAS 14416, and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050)

Metro Rail to begin study to improve walkability near 41 stations of phase I network

CMRL officials said existing footpath will be redesigned and relaid, and new ones would also be built. Bids have been floated to rope in a consultant who will provide a detailed project report

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

More than a decade after launching train services, Chennai Metro Rail has taken the first step towards improving walkability in and around the stations in the 54-km phase I network.

Chennai Metro Rail will shortly begin a detailed study to spruce up the pedestrian infrastructure in and around the 41 stations dotting the phase I network.

Such an initiative is also essential to further establish first and last mile connectivity services like feeder vehicles which will drop and pick up passengers between stations and neighbouring areas.

According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) in the 500 metres influence zone of these 41 stations, primarily, the footpath will be re-designed and relaid and wherever it is non-existent, it will be created. Also, lighting will be added wherever necessary and way-finding signage too will be increased in this zone.

"We have floated bids a few days back to bring in a consultant. The firm will study the influence zone of



Risky stretch: Pedestrians walk on an encroached road without footpaths near Arumbakkam Metro Rail station in the city on Tuesday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

each station in the phase I network, and prepare a detailed project report (DPR) suggesting how to redevelop and make the station surroundings pedestrian friendly," an official said.

Multi-modal transport

Besides, the consultant must also chalk out a plan to create infrastructure which includes multi-modal transport integration with interchange for intra-city buses, inter-city buses, Metro Rail, MRTS stations, bus bays, off road parking bays, foot-over-bridges, subways, covered walkways, bicycle parking, dedicated pick-up and drop-off bays for private vehicles, autorickshaws, taxis, feeder services, vending zones, and public art to enhance

the streetscape. The firm will take about four months to submit the report to CMRL. Subsequently, CMRL will hand over the DPR to Greater Chennai Corporation for implementing the work.

As CMRL has held talks with Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) to roll out buses which will serve as feeder vehicles from stations, it is imperative to create safe spaces around stations to help them walk to the closest bus stop.

Eventually, CMRL hopes that if such infrastructure improvements occur, it could pull more people in to travelling by metro.

While the plans on paper look good, unless implemented well, commuters

have a tough time accessing stations of the mass rapid transit systems in the city.

K.G. Manoharan, a resident of Tamilar Veethi who frequently uses the Arumbakkam Metro Rail station to go to Chennai airport, said, there is barely any usable footpath leading to the station. "The surrounding area is flooded with encroachment. Sometimes, there is also sewage overflow near the station. Without a footpath and heavy flow of traffic near the station, it is difficult for commuters like me to walk to the station. When people are expected to use public transport, the authorities should also make sure, we can also safely walk to the station," he said.

Doctors remove non-functional portion of lung in infant

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Doctors of MGM Healthcare Malar, Adyar, performed a Video-Assisted Thoracoscopic Surgery (VATS), a minimally invasive procedure, on a one-year-old girl to remove a congenitally developed non-functional portion of the lung, lower lobe of the left lung.

The condition, which is

known as bronchopulmonary sequestration – a congenital malformation of the airway and lung – was diagnosed during foetal development and closely monitored until the child turned one.

The condition is rare, accounting for about two per cent of congenital lung anomalies, a press release said.

During surgery, the team removed the affected

lower lobe of the left lung and ligated the abnormal blood supply from the aorta to the diseased segment. "Until one year of age, the baby was asymptomatic. She was under constant follow-up of the neonatal and paediatric team due to the risk of infections and bleeding. We wanted the child to reach the optimal age and weight to plan the procedure," Karpaga Vinayagam, Senior Consul-

tant, Paediatric Surgery, who led the team, said.

Quick recovery

Minimally invasive approach meant less post-operative pain, a shorter hospital stay, and faster recovery compared to conventional open surgery. "Paediatric anaesthesia is challenging due to the size of the babies. What is more challenging is that VATS requires one lung ventilation

Leela Samson pays ₹8 lakh for remarks against dance intern

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Tuesday quashed a criminal case pending against renowned Bharatanatyam dancer and former director of Kalakshetra Foundation Leela Samson, 74, after she settled the matter by paying ₹8 lakh to the complainant, a female dance intern, whom she had described as the "mistress" of a male faculty member in her Facebook post.

Justice M. Nirmal Kumar allowed the quash petition filed by Ms. Samson after she and also the complainant appeared before the court and stated that the matter had been resolved amicably between them. The complainant said, she was not interested in pursuing the criminal case booked under Section 509 (insult to the modesty of a woman) of Indian Penal Code.

"Taking into consideration that the petitioner and the second respondent have resolved their issue, and since the offence under Section 509 IPC is compoundable in nature, this court, in exercise of its jurisdiction under Section 482 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, is inclined to quash the proceedings," the judge wrote while quashing the case pending at the XIII Metropolitan Magistrate court in Saidapet, Chennai.

The judge was told that Ms. Samson had put out

the objectionable Facebook post on December 23, 2022. Aggrieved over the upheal that it had created among social circles, the dance intern lodged a police complaint on March 23, 2023 stating that the derogatory and disparaging post, demeaning the relationship that she had with her mentor, had caused immense trauma to her in personal as well as academic life.

FIR registered

The complainant also obtained a direction from a Metropolitan Magistrate court to register a First Information Report (FIR) and hence the All Women Police in Adyar booked the case against Ms. Samson on July 20, 2023.

They also completed the investigation by examining a number of witnesses and filed a charge sheet against her before the IX Metropolitan Magistrate court in Saidapet on November 17, 2023.

In the meantime, the complainant had also filed a civil suit against Ms. Samson before the Chennai city civil court, which had referred the issue for mediation. The mediation succeeded with both parties signing a settlement agreement on April 15, 2025.

As per the terms of the agreement, the former director of Kalakshetra Foundation had agreed to express regret in public through a post on her Facebook page.

THE HINDU
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CINEMA ARTS EVENTS
MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy, Madras
Today: 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall - The Music Academy Madras - HCL Concerts - Bharatanatyam recital by Vainshavi Srinivasan.

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Today 6.15pm I.Ramakrishnan - Violin Solo, N. Manoj Siva, S. Sunil Kumar. Concert dedicated to Smt Andal & Sri V. Ananthanarayanan. Ragasudha Hall.

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4
Today at 06.30 pm Valmiki's Rama in Various Kandas' s Talk by Abhinav Kadambi. Ph. No: 86105 57987. Rasikas welcome.

Sri Ramanjaneya Trust, Tambaram Sanatorium, Ch-47, Ct: 9445105533
Sri Ramanavami Festival 2026 Today at 7pm Kum. Archana & Kum. Samanvi - Vocal, Madurai Shri. Kishore - Violin, Neyveli Shri K. V. Ramkumar - Mridangam

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha (Regd.) Vanimahall. Ph: 28152166

In association with Sri Kanchi Mahaswami Vidya Mandir Rajakipakkam, Chennai, Integrated Enterprises (India) Ltd and City Union Bank celebrates 18TH NAMASANKERTHANA VAIBHAVAM 2026 at Vani Mahal. Today 4.30 pm Ramadasar, Kabirdasur, Meera Bhajans by Sri O.S. Mukundan Bhagavathar, Sri O.S.Mohan Bhaga vathar and Party. 6.30pm Abhangs by Smt. Savita Sreeram Bhagavathasri and Party. All are welcome.

MISCELLANEOUS

Narada Gana Sabha Trust Ph: 24995201
Today Concluding Day - Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall - at 6.30 pm - Sri R Krishnaswami Memorial Lecture - "Namasankertthan Mummooorthai - Sri Sathguru Swamikal Jaigurunath" - Sadang by H H Maharanyami Sri Sri Muralidhara Swamiji. All are welcome.

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This is to inform all concerned that original property documents related to our Trust property in Puzhal Village, was lost around Porur near GK Cinemas probably at around 5.30 pm on 14th March 2026 and are presently not traceable.
Document Details:
1. Survey 124-Document no. 2259/1999
2. Survey 123-Document no. 98/1999, 9405/1992 and 2160/1980

The above original documents were in my possession earlier. Despite my best efforts to locate them, I have not been able to trace them and they appear to have been lost. I hereby declare that the above documents have not been pledged, mortgaged or given to any bank, financial institution or individual as security. The finder is hereby asked to submit the it to the undersigned within 15 days of circulation of the notice.
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Metrowater to expand 24-hour drinking water supply to more areas in Adyar zone

While work has commenced for areas, including Besant Nagar, Adyar, Taramani, and Thiruvannmiyur covered by the Pallipattu and Thiruvannmiyur water distribution stations, the water agency plans to ensure continuous piped water supply to other parts of Adyar and Kodambakkam zones

WATER WATCH

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

Moving ahead with its goal to provide 24-hour uninterrupted and equitable piped water supply, Chennai Metrowater is finalising a detailed project report covering more parts of Adyar zone under phase II of the project.

While work has commenced for areas, including Besant Nagar, Adyar, Taramani, and Thiruvannmiyur covered by Pallipattu and Thiruvannmiyur water distribution stations, the water agency has proposed to expand the project to ensure continuous piped water supply to other parts of Adyar zone and Kodambakkam zone. It has



Equitable supply: Nearly 42,000 households would get water from Chembarambakkam reservoir and the Nemmeli desalination plant. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

implemented a pilot project in one ward at Valasaravakkam.

Officials of Metrowater said the second phase of the project would be implemented based on the study of Water Corporation of Odisha (WATCO), which will serve as project management consultant. This would also be under

Hybrid Annuity Model – a public private partnership model – wherein the concessionaire must improve operational efficiency and install smart infrastructure.

The three water distribution stations in Velachery, Ekkaduthangal, and Nandanam, and distribution network would be im-

proved to shift from time-bound supply schedules and intermittent water supply. A stakeholders' meeting was recently held in various wards, including 175, 176, and 177, to incorporate residents' suggestions for phase II of the project.

Officials said the Adyar zone, which is currently

being provided with 95 million litres of water a day (mld), would experience an improved water supply of 140 mld once the project is completed.

The distribution network would be divided into district metered areas (DMA), each equipped with flow and pressure monitoring devices, to track water flow and reduce losses. Each DMA would cover up to 3,000 connections.

Nearly 42,000 households, including Velachery and Ekkaduthangal, would get supply from Chembarambakkam reservoir and Nemmeli desalination plant.

During the meeting, residents sought increase in water supply to Velachery from the existing 12 mld to 20 mld to enable tail-end areas to receive sufficient

water and called for tamper-proof metering system.

Geetha Ganesh, secretary, AGS Colony Residents Welfare Association, Velachery West, said the area now has more apartments owing to urbanisation and the old, damaged pipelines must be replaced to provide equitable supply.

Officials said another stakeholders' meeting would be held before the DPR is finalised. The concessionaire would have command and control centres across the zone to get alerts on drop in water supply.

The distribution network, whether damaged due to ageing or inadequacy in capacity owing to urbanisation, would be improved based on an infrastructure condition assessment.

INBRIEF



SRMIST holds conference on nursing competence

The SRM College of Nursing of the SRM Institute of Science and Technology, organised an international conference on cultural competence in nursing on Tuesday. Jothi Clara Micheal, Founder of Healthbridge and former Country Director of Nursing at Gleneagles Hospitals, inaugurated the conference. Shauna Houk, University Teaching Fellow and Associate Director for Undergraduate Studies Academics at Dalhousie University, Canada, and R. Jayanthi, Dean (Medical), SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre, participated.

Free laptops given to students of Thakkar Bapa Vidyalaya

Students of Thakkar Bapa Vidyalaya Samithi received free laptops on Tuesday. Corporation Councillor Raja Anbazhagan distributed the laptops to the students.

Road safety, timely care crucial to reduce head injury deaths: experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ahead of World Head Injury Awareness Day, marked annually on March 20, experts from Kauvery Hospital highlighted the importance of road safety in preventing accidents and access to Level I trauma care.

Early treatment at a Level I Trauma Care Centre, which represents the highest level of emergency care, during the 'golden hour' can significantly improve survival and reduce disability in patients with severe head injuries, experts said.

Prevention is key

Addressing the media, Krish Sridhar, Group Mentor – Neurosciences and Director, Institute of Brain & Spine, Kauvery Hospital, Radial Road, said that the



Director-General of Prisons K. Shankar (third from left) at an event on trauma care organised by Kauvery Hospital.

first step is prevention. "Many people continue to have a 'not me' attitude, assuming they will not be involved in road accidents. Wearing a helmet or seat belt should be a priority. There needs to be a shift in mindset," he noted, adding that a fully equipped trauma centre can further reduce harm, as time is critical.

K. Shankar, Director General of Prisons and Correctional Services, who

was the chief guest at the event, said that road accidents were on the rise and motorists often violated rules. He stressed that rules must be followed.

'Urgent intervention'

Ranganathan Jothi, Chief Brain & Spine Surgeon and Director of Neurosciences, Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, said, "Many serious head injuries require urgent neurosurgical intervention. Immediate access

to neurosurgical expertise, advanced imaging, and intensive care all available in a Level I Trauma Care Centre can make the difference between life and death or between full recovery and long-term disability."

Aravindan Selvaraj, Co-Founder and Executive Director, Kauvery Group of Hospitals, said trauma teams across the Kauvery network are equipped to provide emergency care.

CPI(M) firm on demand for more seats

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

State secretary of the CPI (M) P. Shanmugam said on Tuesday the party was firm that it would contest more seats than the six it did in the 2021 Assembly poll.

Talking to reporters at 'Anna Arivalayam' the headquarters of the DMK, where seat-sharing talks

were held, Mr. Shanmugam said the CPI(M) would not accept the suggestion that it should scale down its claims since more parties had joined the DMK alliance.

The CPI(M) was allotted six seats in the 2021 polls, but the DMK leadership is offering only five now. The party was not ready to accept the offer in the third

round of talks held on Tuesday.

"Delay is inevitable when there are more parties in an alliance, but we will continue to make efforts to secure more seats," he said.

Each party was holding talks individually with the DMK, the leader of the alliance. "It is the right of a political party to get seats

proportionate to its strength. We have no objection to the Congress or other parties getting more seats. We are demanding seats commensurate with our strength," he said, when asked about TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai's remark that allies should not complain about the allocation of more seats to the Congress.

Car driver arrested in hit-and-run at Vadapalani

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Traffic Investigation Wing, Pondy Bazaar, arrested a car driver in connection with a hit-and-run case that claimed the life of an autorickshaw driver.

Police said the accident occurred on the night of March 14 at Nerkundram Pathai in Vadapalani. The accused, while driving a car, allegedly rammed into an autorickshaw and fled the scene. The autorickshaw driver sustained severe injuries and died on the spot before an ambulance could reach the spot. A case was registered at the Pondy Bazaar Traffic Investigation Wing police station. Acting on CCTV camera footage and sustained efforts, the police traced and apprehended the accused on March 15.

During interrogation, the accused confessed that he was driving under the influence of alcohol and was driving recklessly to entertain his friends at the time of the incident.

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Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. and Printed by Ra Babu Vijay at THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Plot 6-B & B-7, CMDA Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu Dist., Pin 603209. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 751X

CMVK A CH-CHE



Nothing at all

The Centre must negotiate in good faith with Ladakhi leadership

Activist Sonam Wangchuk’s release on March 14 ended a months-long legal and political standoff between his allies and Ladakh’s leadership on one hand and the Centre on the other. Detaining him under the National Security Act 1980, the Centre alleged that he was the “chief provocateur” of the September 2025 violent clashes in Leh that left four dead, and dubbed his presence in the region a catalyst for an “Arab Spring-like” mobilisation to force its hand on Ladakh’s constitutional status. The Centre also argued that given Ladakh’s borders with China and Pakistan, continued “instigation” by a high-profile figure such as Wangchuk threatened territorial stability. About six months later, the Ministry of Home Affairs modified its order, intending to create an environment of “peace, stability, and mutual trust” and resume formal talks with the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA). But even as a judicial commission was still investigating the September violence, Wangchuk’s legal team and his wife Gitanjali Angmo had successfully undermined the government’s case. Foremost, the alleged evidence of incitement was a translation of a short speech padded with pages of “aspirations” – a legally dubious pattern seen in the Elgar Parishad, Delhi liquor scam, and G.N. Saibaba cases. His lawyers also pointed to Wangchuk’s social media posts condemning the unrest that day. The Supreme Court had also expressed serious concerns over Wangchuk’s health in Jodhpur jail. His release came just three days before the Court’s final hearing on the matter, letting the Ministry to avoid a potentially embarrassing ruling that could have deemed the detention arbitrary. But while Wangchuk’s release has defused the immediate tension, the political situation remains fundamentally unresolved. Two days on, Leh saw massive rallies for the first time since September 2025, while Kargil observed a shut-down, with local leaders saying that the agitation for constitutional safeguards would continue. Talks between Ladakh bodies and the Ministry have however been inconclusive, with LAB and the KDA reiterating their demands for statehood and Sixth Schedule status – already recommended by the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes and promised in the BJP’s 2020 election manifesto. Crucially, other activists, including Deldan Namgyal and Smanla Dorje, remain in detention. In effect, what Wangchuk’s detention was meant to serve is unclear, beyond allowing the Centre to brandish its heavy hand, worsening his health, and stalling negotiations. Unless the Centre can negotiate in good faith with the Ladakhi leadership and provide concrete timelines, the people of Ladakh will not get their due.

Prison outbreak

India’s overcrowded jails pose a serious health risk to inmates

The public health crisis in India’s prisons is distinguished by its poorer infrastructure and a general disregard for treating ailments until they become inconvenient. A prisoner does not lose the right to health, a point courts have repeatedly stressed; yet, between August 20, 2025, and March 9, 2026, around 92 inmates at the Jalpaiguri Central Correctional Home were infected with herpes simplex virus (HSV) and seven of them died. HSV is common in the general population but experts have said that in immunocompromised or overcrowded populations with poor care, it can lead to encephalitis, which is often fatal. The Home’s 171% occupancy rate rendered good hygiene and isolation a luxury. According to the 2023 Prison Statistics of India, district prisons in West Bengal have reported occupancy rates exceeding 160% and certain facilities, such as the Kandi Sub-Jail, have historically reached staggering levels of over 400%. While the State has many foreign national inmates, overcrowding is a persistent fact of India’s correctional facilities. In 2023, 30% of inmates in 10 prisons in Kerala were found to have skin diseases caused by humidity and a lack of personal space. A 2023 study in *The Lancet Public Health* found prisoners in India five times more likely to develop tuberculosis (TB) than the general population. In 2025, the Home Ministry ordered prison screening camps as unventilated environments allow TB to spread rapidly. The Nagpur and Indore central jails had major COVID-19 outbreaks. According to the India Justice Report 2025, HIV prevalence among inmates is also significantly higher than the national average due to shared equipment and inadequate screening at entry. Mandatory, comprehensive medical screening could catch many of these infections before they become injurious, which also requires facilities to have the requisite personnel. But the report also flagged a 43% vacancy rate for medical officers, resulting in the number of inmates per doctor being 2.6 times higher than recommended by the Model Prison Manual. There are also only 25 psychologists for India’s 5.7 lakh inmates. Filling this gap requires integrating prisons into the National Health Mission, ensuring a sufficient number of health workers trained to manage outbreaks, and enforcing the Manual’s standards uniformly across States. As West Bengal’s actions in 2020 illustrate – temporarily releasing thousands of undertrials to relieve overcrowding in the South 24 Parganas District Correctional Home and the Baruipur Central Jail – the solutions are not confined to health. The judiciary must fast-track cases involving undertrials, who constitute the majority of inmates, expand the use of bail and non-custodial alternatives for minor offences and expedite the repatriation of foreign nationals.

India’s West Asia reset, more sinned against than sinning

During the past month, Indian policy towards West Asia has stirred domestic controversy. As substantive Indian interests are at stake, a professional assessment, based on two trends, is offered without wading into the domestic political blame game.

A link to two trends

First, over the past decade, India has raised its diplomatic engagement with West Asia. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has made 15 visits to the six countries of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) – some after a multi-decade hiatus. He also visited Israel twice, and the Palestinian Authority and Iran each once. Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements (CEPA) have been signed with the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Oman, and similar negotiations are underway with the GCC and Israel.

With over \$160 billion in bilateral trade and 10 million diaspora, the GCC ranks as India’s largest socio-economic partner. Last decade’s engagements spurred synergy, although the promised investments have lagged. India’s political gains include a de-hyphenation with Pakistan, greater strategic convergence with stronger defence and security tie-ups and growing acceptance of India as a responsible and friendly status quo power.

Second, the Gulf monarchies’ ardour for a foreign power is normally rooted in the foreign power’s potential contribution to the security and stability of their royal family, state and region – in that order. Exceptional turmoil in West Asia since October 2023, and a three-week-old war with the GCC countries under direct Iranian drone and missile attacks and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, have accentuated their search for a better security paradigm than the eight-decade-old regional Pax Americana.

The recent reset in India’s diplomacy in West Asia largely acknowledges the aforementioned two trends and attempts to harness them to serve India’s national interest. To their credit, India’s policymakers have finally realised which side of the bread is buttered, and have launched a qualitative upscaling of a symbiosis with key West Asian countries. Recent initiatives, such as Mr. Modi’s visit to Israel and his individual phone calls to all his GCC counterparts during the early days of the hostilities, have not only assured them of India’s categorical support to their security and stability but also conveyed that India shares and prioritises their concerns at this critical juncture. Later, he also spoke with his Iranian counterpart.

The new doctrine is clearer-sighted and emphasises hard diplomacy. This reset is bereft of two traditional aspects that often dampen the bilateral amity: First, India did not chant the traditional please-all mantras that left all



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stakeholders partially satisfied and India at the margins of the arena. There was no attempt to “balance” its public policy on controversial issues such as the “two-state solution” and Iran’s quest for nuclear technology. Second, India’s statements reflected its views without needless third-party citations. This demonstrates India’s growing confidence as a credible and autonomous power.

Some domestic detractors have criticised the policy reset on multiple grounds. First, Mr. Modi’s Israel visit (February 25-26) that concluded two days before Tel Aviv unleashed a military campaign against Iran is seen as untimely. Second, the perceived abandonment of India’s traditional support for Palestinians and Iran is seen as immoral. Third, South Block is accused of surrendering India’s sovereign autonomy to western dictates. Fourth, this activist reset may lead to strategic overreach with concomitant challenges such as exposure to security threats and costly defence tie-ups abroad.

The dates of the Prime Minister’s visit to Israel were likely to have been set weeks in advance without any premonition of the February 28 offensive. The West Asian situation being perennially on the front burner makes any such visit risky, giving the ex-post facto criticism of the timing an unfair advantage of 50:50 hindsight. At the same time, the focus of the visit being bilateral renders it in a different domain.

Where other international actors stand

The perceived “immorality” of India’s reset is largely misdirected and should be aimed at more worthy targets, such as China, Russia and Pakistan. Beijing siphoned off nearly 90% of the sanctioned Iranian oil exports, rendering only lip service to Tehran; Russia, which signed a 20-year Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Treaty with Iran last year, has also underdelivered. And last year, Pakistani generals promised to nuke Israel if it attacked Iran; they are now U.S. President Donald Trump’s favourites. Similarly, even the Arabs and Muslim states were conspicuously silent during the Gaza conflict.

While the Indian reset is a long-overdue recognition of the tectonic geopolitical shifts in West Asia, the pendulum swung to the other extreme and is being gradually realigned with national interests. The regional dynamic being notoriously mercurial, India should strive to keep its options more open. The Palestine Cause cannot be wished away forever. At the end of the day, Iran would remain an important player for India as an oil supplier and as a large market for Indian products, reconstruction projects and services. Iran, which borders Pakistan and Afghanistan, could be a strategic ally. Further, if subterranean trends such as growing Arab unease with the American and Israeli Armageddon, the

India needs balance, sensitivity and agility to leverage emerging opportunities in West Asia

A bit of a blur over India’s new carbon credit plan

A significant policy announcement in the Union Budget 2026, involving a massive ₹20,000 crore outlay for a carbon credit programme, has sparked a wave of confusion and conflicting reports, pitting a clear-cut governmental road map for heavy industry against a burgeoning narrative of a new income stream for India’s farmers. At the heart of the debate is a fundamental question. Is this Budget allocation designed to fund Carbon Capture, Utilization, and Storage (CCUS) technologies for smokestack industries? Or is it a pioneering scheme to help farmers earn carbon credits through sustainable agriculture? Evidence from official documents suggests the first, but a persistent parallel narrative, echoed in several media reports, insists on the second.

The first is the CCUS for “Hard-to-Abate” Industries. The unambiguous anchor for the Budget announcement is the “R&D Roadmap for CCUS”, released by the Department of Science and Technology (DST) in December 2025. This technical document, which forms the basis of the budgetary provision, leaves little room for ambiguity regarding its scope and intent. The road map explicitly identifies its target sectors, power, steel, cement, refineries, and chemicals. These are labelled as “hard-to-abate” industries where process emissions are concentrated, measurable, and technically challenging to eliminate through renewable energy alone. The proposed ₹20,000 crore over five years is earmarked for large-scale deployment of CCUS technologies, essentially capturing carbon dioxide from factory flue gases and either using it industrially or storing it underground.

Not on the list

Crucially, agriculture is conspicuously absent from this list of CCUS sectors. The road map acknowledges agriculture as a source of greenhouse gases (primarily methane and nitrous oxide) but only in an inventory context. It



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The strategy requires distinct focus on both ‘smokestack’ and ‘soil’ initiatives

explicitly excludes agriculture from CCUS strategies because agricultural emissions are diffuse, biologically mediated, and not suited to the point-source capture technology that defines CCUS. The road map draws a clear line between CCUS (preventing new industrial emissions) and Carbon Dioxide Removal or CDR (drawing down existing atmospheric CO₂), where agriculture, through soil carbon sequestration, biochar, and agroforestry, plays a starring role.

The second is the persistent counter-narrative of farmers as climate solutionists. Despite this clear industrial focus, articles and social media discourse have propagated a different story. This narrative posits that the budgetary outlay will directly enable farmers to participate in carbon markets by adopting regenerative practices, turning “farms into climate solutions”.

The root of the confusion

This interpretation appears to conflate two distinct concepts. The Budget’s CCUS fund (for industrial carbon capture) and the broader, evolving voluntary carbon market in India, where agriculture and forestry projects are already beginning to generate credits for global and domestic buyers. Proponents of the “farmer” narrative point to the growing global and domestic demand for nature-based carbon credits. Several private sector initiatives and State-level programmes are already piloting models where farmers are compensated for practices that enhance soil organic carbon. The confusion likely stems from the Budget’s use of the term “carbon credit programme” in a broader sense, while its detailed architecture, as per the DST road map, is exclusively industrial.

Analysts say the confusion highlights a communication gap and a policy opportunity. The DST road map is a technically sound, sector-specific document, but the Budget’s use of the more familiar term ‘carbon credit’ has blurred lines. Mention of a “programme” amid

Saudi-UAE rift, the Iraq-Iran estrangement, and aggressive positioning by Pakistan and Türkiye are taken on board, a more nuanced reset would have suitably underscored continuity and inclusion. In retrospect, India could have reacted faster to the developments, such as the assassination of Iran’s Supreme Leader and the appointment of his successor. Political correctness should not make India taciturn, as the diplomatic doublespeak offers many ways to skin the proverbial cat. India’s relations with the U.S. and Israel are not so fragile as to be upended by our agreeing to disagree. Finally, India could have rendered more humanitarian relief to millions affected by the hostilities.

An opportunity for India

The ongoing reset should accommodate two incipient, but profound, regional movements with long-term positives for India. First, the long-standing “Oil-for-Security” compact between the Washington-led West and the moderate Arab regimes has become a collateral casualty of the ongoing U.S.-Israel war against Iran. The U.S. joined Israel in attacking Iran without prior notification to the GCC, ignoring the latter’s cautionary advice. The West not only failed to protect them from Iranian retaliation, but its military bases on their soil became lightning rods for the Iranian attacks. Now, they fear that the U.S. may abruptly conclude the campaign, leaving them to face Iran’s wrath. Once the dust settles, the GCC states may reduce their reliance on the U.S. and diversify their security partnership options to countries such as India, which are less likely to act as a Praetorian Guard. India’s response to any such proposal ought to be based on a careful SWOT analysis with clear rules of engagement.

Second, the Iranian retaliations against the GCC have disrupted business activity and supply chains, and an early return to ‘business as usual’ appears unlikely. The GCC’s appeal as an oasis of eco-political stability in the turbulent region has taken a serious long-term knock, leading to some stakeholders’ clamour for a “GCC+1” strategy. India’s eco-diplomacy must strive to position India as a viable and attractive alternative hub to the GCC’s ritzy but fragile hotspots, which thrived by weaning away capital and talent from India. The current commotion is a historic opportunity to seize what is rightfully ours.

To remain relevant and effective, a country needs a dynamic foreign policy grounded in realism and national interest. Its execution requires the right mix of consistency, agility and modulation. As India’s West Asia policy matures, it is relevant to recall British Prime Minister Lord Palmerston’s maxim, “We have no eternal allies, and we have no perpetual enemies. Our interests are eternal and perpetual...”

discussion of agricultural carbon credits has led some to expect a funded scheme for farmers. This expectation is plausible, as the Agriculture Ministry has been exploring soil health and climate-resilient farming for years. A structured carbon farming programme is a logical next step, but it would need separate policy, funding, and institutional frameworks distinct from the costly, tech-heavy CCUS initiative.

The government faces the task of clarifying this distinction to manage expectations. The ₹20,000 crore CCUS programme is a critical pillar for decarbonising industry, a sector vital for growth but also responsible for a quarter of India’s emissions. Its success is non-negotiable for meeting net-zero goals.

Simultaneously, the powerful narrative around farmers and carbon credits highlights a massive parallel opportunity. India’s vast agricultural lands hold immense potential for carbon sequestration. A separate, well-designed policy to create a trusted domestic carbon market for agriculture could unlock enormous economic and environmental benefits, truly creating a “new income stream” for farmers.

A multi-sectoral approach is needed

The current debate underscores a pivotal moment in India’s climate strategy. Budget 2026 has firmly placed its ₹20,000 crore bet on industrial decarbonisation through CCUS. The “farmer carbon credit” story, while not funded by this specific outlay, reflects a powerful and growing reality in the voluntary carbon space and a compelling demand for a parallel policy initiative. The path ahead requires the government to clearly demarcate these two crucial fronts in the climate fight – smokestack and soil – while advancing both with equal ambition. The confusion may be born of conflation today, but it points to the comprehensive, multi-sectoral approach India will need to forge a sustainable future.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Watch and sign

India’s decision to ink a trade deal with the United States only after clarity on tariff issues may come unstuck considering the impulsive nature of U.S. President Donald Trump. Those who had been exporting to the U.S. have burnt their fingers already and will be weary of considering exporting their products to the U.S.

hereafter. The Centre may like to improve and stabilise its diplomatic ties with the U.S. but the Indian exporters may not want to take a risk. Indian exporters, who thrive on thin margins of profit, will keep themselves away from American importers as the imposition of harsh American tariffs at any given point of time cannot be ruled out (Front page,

March 17).
V. Lakshmanan,
Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

The government’s decision reflects a pragmatic and strategically sound approach. A premature agreement without clarity on how competing economies are treated could weaken India’s export competitiveness in key sectors such as textiles,

pharmaceuticals, and engineering goods.
Vidyasagar Reddy Kethiri,
Hanamkonda, Telangana

Political graffiti removal

The Election Commission of India recently announced the election schedule for four States and a Union Territory. Soon after, municipal authorities across cities and towns began removing political graffiti

and wall writings put up by various political parties. Why should taxpayers’ money be spent to clean up publicity material created by political parties? The government is now spending significant resources on labour and paint to erase these writings from public walls. If political parties are allowed to use public spaces for party or party leaders’ publicity, they

should either be required to pay a fee for such use or be made responsible for removing the graffiti within a stipulated period of time. In case of non-compliance, the authorities should recover the cost and initiate appropriate legal action.

Y.R.M. Rao,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Why the affiliation system is outdated

An often less discussed feature of the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020 is the new regulatory system envisaged for affiliating colleges. The objective of the new system is to foster empowerment and autonomy by gradually phasing out the affiliation system over a period of 15 years through a process of graded autonomy.

The NEP suggests that each existing university should play the role of a mentor for its affiliated colleges, and enable them to develop their own capabilities and achieve minimum benchmarks in academic and curricular matters, teaching and assessment, governance reforms, financial robustness, and administrative efficiency in order to become self-reliant. All affiliated colleges will have to attain the minimum required standards to secure accreditation benchmarks and acquire the status of an autonomous degree-granting institution. Needless to say, it is a big reform for which nation-wide efforts and governmental support is a *sine qua non*.

Untethering colleges

The college-university affiliation system has long served as the foundational structure for higher education and is so deeply entrenched in the Indian higher education system that disassociating colleges with the university sounds unrealistic. Universities conduct affiliation for colleges in accordance with the University Grants Commission (UGC) guidelines to maintain academic standards, ensure uniform curriculum and examinations, and regulate infrastructure and faculty quality. Moreover, college affiliation in India is not a one-time process. The affiliation is usually granted initially for one year and renewed annually or periodically.

However, while the conventional university affiliation model once provided centralised control and administrative



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The university affiliation system is now riddled with systemic inefficiencies, archaic academic rigidity, and administrative challenges that impede the progress of colleges

stability, it now seems to hinder the growth, autonomy, and quality of colleges. The university affiliation system is now riddled with systemic inefficiencies, archaic academic rigidity, and administrative challenges that impede the progress of colleges.

Multiple challenges

One of the most significant problems with the affiliation system is the overwhelming burden it places on universities. Most universities in India are affiliated with hundreds of colleges, and entrusted to manage examinations, evaluate answer scripts, design curriculum, monitor college compliance, and oversee academic and extracurricular activities for an overwhelming number of students. The attention of resource strained universities, especially State universities, gets diverted from their core functions, such as research, innovation, faculty development, and collaboration, due to heavy administrative workloads. As a result, universities are compelled to act merely as bureaucratic bodies instead of pushing the boundaries of knowledge both for students and faculty.

The lack of autonomy for affiliated colleges poses another challenge. Under the present university affiliation system, it is mandatory for all colleges to follow the regulations, syllabi, examination patterns, and administrative instructions issued by the affiliating university. This dependency prevents colleges from designing their own courses that align with their local or industrial needs, and emerging market trends. This rigidity imposes uniformity at the cost of creativity, denying colleges the freedom to differentiate themselves through specialised courses, modern pedagogical practices, or interdisciplinary initiatives. As a result, the potential for innovation is stifled.

Then there is the slow pace at which curriculum reforms take

place under the university affiliation model. Since universities oversee a large number of colleges, revising curricula requires extensive consultations, committee meetings with the board of studies and department councils, and administrative approvals from academic councils. This process often takes a very long time, causing course content to become outdated by the time reforms are implemented. The educational needs of students in disciplines such as engineering and technology change very rapidly, but the affiliation system is simply not agile enough to respond with the required speed.

Moreover, the affiliation model, despite its best intentions to standardise education, has led to quite the opposite. While all colleges may follow the same curriculum, the actual delivery of education varies drastically due to the huge gaps in infrastructure. Many colleges operate with inadequate laboratories, insufficient library facilities, outdated equipment, and a shortage of qualified teachers. Such disparities weaken the credibility of standardised learning outcomes, as students from different colleges under the same university may graduate with vastly different levels of skill and competence.

An alternate model

While the university affiliation system once played a vital role in expanding higher education, its limitations now hinder progressive educational aspirations.

Instead of affiliations, colleges may be encouraged to participate in the National Institutional Ranking Framework/National Board of Accreditation exercise which is grounded in established quality criteria. The future of higher education in India hinges on empowering institutions with autonomy, flexibility, and the capacity to innovate freely – conditions the affiliation system can no longer adequately provide.

The cost of energy transition

Protests against the hydroelectric project in the Western Ghats just got new life

STATE OF PLAY

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The Karnataka High Court, earlier this month, directed the State government to stop work in the forest area for the Sharavathi Pumped Storage Hydroelectric Project, until further orders. A group of environmentalists had moved the Court, challenging the State Wildlife Board's approval for the proposed project in the Sharavathi Lion-Tailed Macaque Wildlife Sanctuary which is part of the Western Ghats, and a biodiversity hotspot. The Court's order boosted the morale of the environmentalists, who have been opposing the project since it was proposed in 2017.

The Karnataka Power Corporation Limited (KPCL) proposed the project in the valley of the Sharavathi river, which flows for about 130 km through the Western Ghats before reaching the Arabian sea. The river is already the State's primary hydel power source, with four major power stations operating in its valley.

The KPCL aims to generate 2,000 MW through this project to meet peak-hour energy demands, which can touch 18,000 MW daily. The project has been defended on the grounds that the Central Electricity Authority has recommended a transition to clean energy, targeting 50% non-fossil fuel capacity by 2030. The cost of the project which was estimated to be around ₹4,800 crore in 2017, has gone up to nearly ₹10,240 crore.

Furthermore, while the project has received the approval of the State Wildlife Board and an in-principle approval from the National



Board of Wildlife (NBWL), forest and environmental clearances are still pending.

Environmental concerns

The Karnataka State Wildlife Board gave its approval for the project in January 2025, with certain conditions. Initially, the KPCL had estimated that more than 16,000 trees were to be cut for the project. The board suggested that it be reduced to 7,000 to 8,000 trees.

Even so, the project continued to face stiff opposition from different groups. Environmentalists, locals, farmers' organisations, and heads of religious institutions spread over the Shivamogga and Uttara Kannada districts have been protesting against the project. They have held several meetings and highlighted the destruction the project will cause to the forests and the endangered species of flora and fauna, including the lion-tailed macaques, who are endemic to the place. Local residents, who have witnessed frequent landslips during heavy rains in the past few years, are worried that the construction of the tunnel might cause irreparable damage to the region. They are also concerned that the implementing agency might take additional forest land to lay the lines needed to carry the power generated by the project. Petitioners, including environmentalist Akhilesh Chipkli, have alleged that

the project is against the laws that prohibit non-forest activities in the region.

Interestingly, a site inspection report filed by Praneetha Paul, Deputy Inspector General of Forest of the Regional Office of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF), did not recommend the project proposal. The officer stated that the construction of new roads, and the widening of existing roads and other structures would result in the complete destruction of the wet evergreen forests, and that cutting trees would isolate the population of lion-tailed macaques. Environmentalists have cited this report as a key document to support their arguments.

Considering the serious opposition from the public, representatives of the KPCL held meetings in parts of Shivamogga and Uttara Kannada in October 2025 to defend the project. A team official tried to convince the people that the impact of the project would be minimal. They also argued that the project was necessary considering the need to reduce dependence on fossil fuels for energy production.

Enduring fight

However, the KPCL's efforts have failed to convince the protesters. Considering the stiff opposition, the MoEF sent an expert panel to visit the project site, and the panel, in its report, stated that the "limited operational benefit offered by the project seems outweighed by the irreversible ecological, environmental and social costs involved."

The legal setback and the adverse expert report have created a significant hurdle for the project's proponents. The KPCL's next move before the Court and the NBWL will be keenly watched.

T.N. needs more basic science funding to create green tech

Although revenue spending on science and technology has risen in recent years, State funding for fundamental research has been modest

DATA POINT

Vasudevan Mukunth

As Tamil Nadu approaches its Assembly elections, its ambition to become a \$1-trillion economy by 2030 and its position as one of India's leading industrial and knowledge hubs means it's worth examining how the State has invested in science and environmental issues in the last five years.

First, the State's strategy for the environment has been to integrate climate action across sectors rather than increase a core allocation for the environment and climate change department. Within this framework, it has launched a series of dedicated environmental missions since 2021. In the 2021-22 fiscal, the State allocated ₹500 crore to establish the Tamil Nadu Climate Change Mission – one of the first of its kind among States – and another ₹150 crore for the Wetlands Mission to restore 100 ecologically sensitive water bodies. The following year, the State established the Tamil Nadu Green Climate Fund with a ₹1,000 crore corpus to finance renewable energy, electric mobility, pollution-control technologies, forest conservation, and circular-economy projects, among other climate-related technologies.

By 2023-24, it had expanded its conservation efforts by dedicating ₹10 crore to Project Nilgiri Tahr and scaling up the Green Tamil Nadu Mission to increase forest cover. The 2024-25 Budget expanded the Sustainably Harnessing Ocean Resources (SHORE) scheme to strengthen the blue economy, and provided subsidies for electric vehicles.

Spending surged in 2025-26 as the government allocated ₹21,178 crore to the energy department, which includes investments in renewable generation, pumped-storage hydro projects, battery energy storage systems, and other infras-

tructure, and ₹100 crore to build new basic science research centres in Chennai and Coimbatore.

Not enough funds

Second, although revenue spending on Science and Technology (S&T) has risen in recent years, it still represents only a small share of the State's broader fiscal priorities. It is important to note that according to the National S&T Management Information System (NSTMIS), Tamil Nadu had spent more than ₹600 crore a year on overall R&D until 2020-21. The difference arises because the NSTMIS assesses R&D expenditure across departments rather than going by the expenses under the S&T head.

Even this figure has two important dimensions. For Tamil Nadu, this expense is spread across agriculture (crop research, pest control, etc.), veterinary services (livestock and aquaculture research), public health (clinical research at State medical colleges), and other applied sectors. Dimension 1: applied research doesn't produce the underlying Intellectual property (IP). Dimension 2: in the same period when Tamil Nadu spent just over ₹600 crore a year on R&D, Gujarat spent ₹922 crore and Uttar Pradesh, more than ₹1,000 crore.

Chart 1 shows the expenditure on research and development by select State governments.

A global comparison is possible as well. When South Korea's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per capita was what Tamil Nadu's is today, it was already allocating 1.2% of its GDP to R&D.

However, Tamil Nadu's total R&D expenditure is under 0.5% of its Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP), meaning that the State is currently spending less than half of what is required (by the South Korean yardstick) to foster a world-class innovation ecosystem.

The State's dedicated budgetary allocation for Science and Technology in particular has been much lower. In the decade or so leading up to 2021-22, Tamil Nadu

had an annual revenue expenditure averaging around ₹10 crore, primarily for running the Tamil Nadu State Council for Science and Technology (TNSCST), the Science City in Chennai, the Tamil Nadu Science and Technology Centre, and for student projects and popularising science. But as it pivoted to being a technology-driven economy and got going on its 'net zero' commitment, the figures began to climb. By the 2025-26 fiscal, the allocation reached ₹67.5 crore and in 2026-27, an estimated ₹81 crore.

Need to focus on basic science

While the increase between pre-2021 and 2021-27 is eightfold in nominal terms, it is dwarfed by the allocations for climate-related missions. The State set aside more than ₹21,000 crore for the energy sector in 2025-26 alone. In fact, until it announced the ₹100 crore package in the 2025-26 Budget for the new basic science research centres in Chennai and Coimbatore, State funding for fundamental research was modest – most of it in the form of small grant programmes (₹10,000 to ₹1,00,000) such as those administered by the TNSCST. Major research institutions in the State, such as the Indian Institute of Technology (Madras) and the Institute of Mathematical Sciences, are mostly funded by the Union government.

Chart 2 shows the budget allocated by the State to the Science and Technology Centre and the Council for Science and Technology.

As a result, the State currently lacks the mature R&D required to develop homegrown technologies. Tamil Nadu's current expenditure risks rendering it a consumer of green technologies rather than a creator of underlying research breakthroughs. For instance, despite Tamil Nadu being a national leader in solar installations, more than 80% of photovoltaic modules in these projects are imported from China or sourced from manufacturing hubs in Gujarat.

Funding gap

The data for the charts were sourced from S&T Research Development Statistics 2022-23 and Tamil Nadu Budget



CHART 1: Expenditure on research and development by select State governments (in ₹ crore)

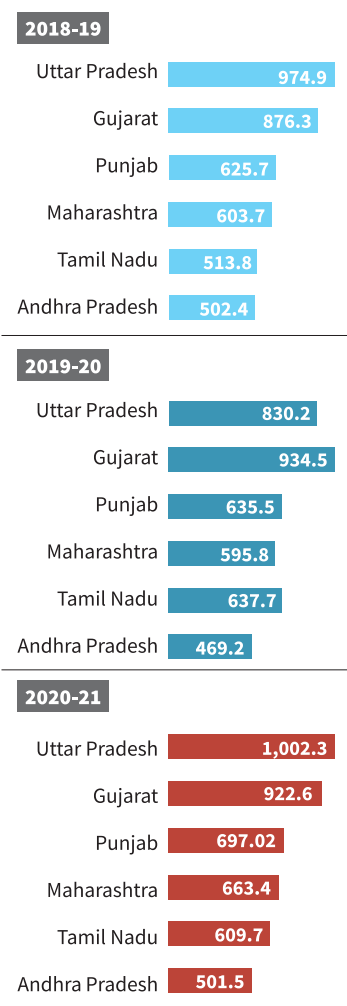
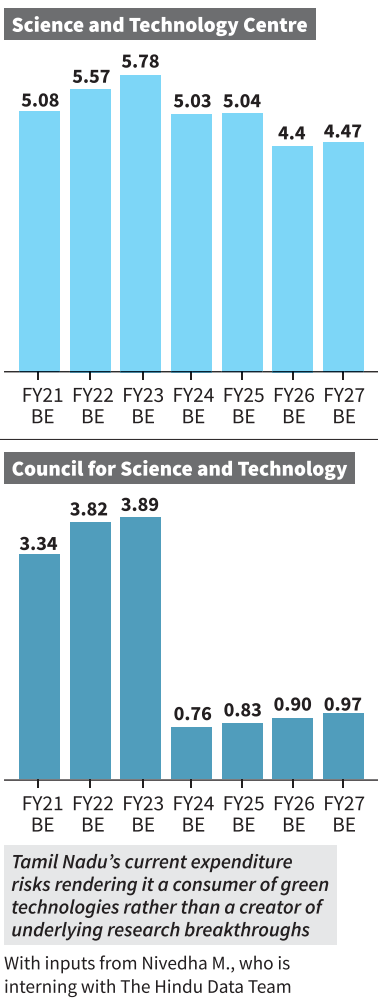


CHART 2: Budget allocated to the Science and Technology Centre and the Council for Science and Technology (in ₹ crore)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The  **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 18, 1976

Coonoor polio vaccine unit to be closed

New Delhi, March 17: The oral polio vaccine production unit at the Pasteur Institute, Coonoor, will be closed with effect from March 31. Meanwhile, there is a move for handing over the institute itself to the Centre.

The closure of the vaccine unit, run with Central grants routed through the Indian Council of Medical Research, was decided upon by the Health Ministry on the basis of the opinion of technical experts who had gone into its defective functioning. The technical opinion was that the unit could not be revived without a very heavy expenditure and that even then it was doubtful whether it would be able to produce good, acceptable and safe vaccine.

One of the factors found to have affected the functioning of the unit was dual control. Although the unit was functioning in the Institute, it was an ICMR project and as such there had been lack of rapport between the unit staff and the Institute Director. The Public Accounts Committee of the Lok Sabha had also commented on this sorry state of affairs.

A suggestion was made at one stage that the Institute managed by an Association be handed over to the Centre to ensure effective functioning of the Institute and the vaccine unit.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 18, 1926

Anglo-Indians and the Army

Allahabad, March 17: In connection with the appeal put forward by Colonel Gidney in the Assembly on behalf of the Anglo-Indian community, *The Pioneer* says that one of the great grievances of Anglo-Indians has been the bar which has been placed upon their entry into the Army, and this, with various other issues attending the welfare of the community, is, *The Pioneer* understands receiving the very earnest consideration of the Government. As a result of the Memorandum presented by the Deputation which recently visited England, Lord Birkeuhead has addressed a lengthy note to the Government in India.

The communication, the paper understands, favours the formation of an Anglo-Indian Unit. The community played a part in the War which has not been properly recognised.

CM
YK

EC deploys over 1,000 central observers



Assam Congress MP Pradyut Bordoloi resigns

'Single-phase poll in Assam favours BJP'



Dr. Anand Kumar

A hill temple returns to centre stage in Kerala politics

Assam's *dramatis personae*: Himanta, Gaurav, immigrants, and development

The Assam battle

Trinamool drops 74 MLAs; Mamata to take on Suvendu in Bhabanipur

As transfers continue, Mamata says EC can 'campaign for BJP'

CM
YK

A CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Maruti Suzuki receives ₹5,786 cr. income tax order

Maruti Suzuki India (MSI) on Tuesday said it had received a draft assessment order worth ₹5,786.4 crore from the income tax authority and the company will challenge the order. “The company has received a Draft Assessment Order for FY 2022-23 wherein certain additions/disallowances amounting to ₹57,864 million with respect to returned income has been proposed,” the carmaker said in a BSE filing. MSI will file its objections before the dispute resolution panel, it stated. There is no impact on financial, operation or other activities of the company due to this order, it added. Maruti Suzuki shares settled at ₹12,993.55 apiece, up 1.88% on the BSE. PTI

‘24-hour Speed Post launch follows months of testing’

The Department of Posts’ (DoP) announcement of 24 and 48-hour guaranteed Speed Post services follows months of testing, and the resolution of a key logistical hurdle, Ministry officials told *The Hindu*. The facility includes letters and parcels between Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Delhi, Chennai and Kolkata. What made the time-bound guarantee possible was getting guaranteed blocks of space on passenger flight cargo holds, which India Post has used for years to transmit Speed Post articles faster. Regular commercial passenger flights routinely carry goods for courier and logistics firms, and India Post has been among those that utilise the spare capacity after the cargo hold is done loading passenger luggage. However, last year, the DoP floated a tender seeking “hard blocked” space, so that excess demand wouldn’t lead to mail bags being tossed out and used in the next flight. “We have five airlines” with hard blocked space, Dushyant Mudgal, Deputy Director General of Mail Operations at the Department of Posts, told *The Hindu*.

Domestic LPG production up 38%, informs Centre

Domestic production now estimated at more than 48,000 tonnes on a day-to-day basis; increase follows issuance of supply maintenance orders

Kalyanaraman M.
CHENNAI

Domestic LPG production has increased 38% till date since the supply maintenance orders were issued, Union government officials said at a briefing on Tuesday.

In February, as per government data, domestic LPG production was slightly more than 1 million tonne. Normally, India’s daily LPG consumption is around 90,000 tonne on an average. Out of this, 55,000 tonnes comes from imports and 35,000 from domestic production on a proportionate basis.

A 38% increase could mean that domestic production is now more than 48,000 tonnes on a day-to-day basis. Of the total LPG consumption, some 85-90% goes into households as cooking gas, while the remaining is for commercial and industrial purposes. Curbing industrial and commercial uses would mean that the daily import requirement has come down to around 30,000 tonne from 55,000 tonne.

The cargo of Shivalik and Nanda Devi, two LPG tankers that left the Strait of Hormuz with naval escort and have currently docked in India, will be adequate for three days of imports, as opposed to two



Kitchen lifeline: Of the total LPG consumption, some 85-90% goes into households as cooking gas. G.N. RAO

days of imports in the past.

About half a dozen LPG tankers bound for India are still in the west of Strait of Hormuz. These carry a total of some 3 lakh tonne of LPG, according to the government. The Indian LPG system works on a continuous supply cycle since there is little long-term storage. The government is working to diversify sources of LPG, too, since most of the supplies were coming from the Persian Gulf in the past. “There is no real substitute for Gulf LPG in the Indian market. While alternative supplies are available, they come with longer shipping times and cannot provide immediate relief,” said Manish Sejwal, Senior Vice President, Commodity Markets - Oil, Rystad Energy, an energy information agency based in Norway.

Qatar to west coast of India takes some four days on an LPG carrier. And a round voyage takes a little more than a week.

LPG ships are available for bringing in the fuel to India. “VLGC freight rates have not risen as sharply as those for crude or LNG carriers, partly because only about 4% of the global VLGC fleet was stranded west of Hormuz,” said Mr. Sejwal. Meanwhile, two LPG vessels of each around 24,000 to 25,000 tonnes cargo are expected to arrive at Visakhapatnam between March 26 and 30. On March 7, a 24,000-tonne LPG vessel had docked Visakhapatnam. Ennore terminal, which sees two or three LPG ship calls a month is expecting an LPG ship on March 21.

(With inputs from Saptaparno Ghosh)

Infosys hits 3-year low on AI fears, war

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Software services firm Infosys Ltd. fell almost 3% to ₹1,215 on the Nifty50 on Tuesday, marking the lowest level since April 2023 on Artificial Intelligence (AI) fears and rising crude prices which could halt the rate-cutting cycle of global central banks.

The stock closed at ₹1,234, or 1.35% lower.

Infosys was not alone as Oracle, Wipro and Persistent Systems slid by about 2% on Tuesday with the ov-



Oracle, Wipro and Persistent Systems slid by about 2%.

erall NiftyIT index sliding almost 1%.

U.S.-based AI firm Anthropic has been consistently releasing multiple updates to its AI tool

Claude with features and plug-ins that can perform tasks such as writing equity research reports, legal reports and even market research reports in addition to coding and creating new applications without human intervention.

Job loss fears

This has stoked fears among Indian IT staff and investors alike on potential job losses and hiring cuts.

However, some industry veterans opine the IT stock sell-off was an overreaction and that Anthropic

would not spell doomsday.

Speaking at an event, CIO of PPFAS AMC Rajiv Thakkar said a further correction in IT stocks may make valuations attractive.

“Agentic AI is a developing theme with implications still debated. In the near term, this shows up as caution, longer decision cycles and selective pressure on base business. Over time, it could contribute to a broader reshaping of value pools, but the timing and magnitude remain uncertain,” as per a Kotak Institutional Research note.

Renault relaunches Duster, bets on hybrids

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Renault re-introduced Renault Duster in India, marking not just the return of a once-popular SUV but a broader strategic reset built around hybrid technology and a multi-power-train approach. The third-generation Duster is priced from about ₹10.3 lakh (ex-showroom).

Malabar Gold set to invest ₹1,580 cr. in showrooms

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Malabar Gold & Diamonds, a jewellery retailer has planned to open 20 new showrooms before March 31, marking one of the fastest showroom rollouts in the country.

With this, the total global showroom count of the firm will rise to 445 across 14 countries. The expansion entails a total investment of ₹1,580 crore and is likely to generate over 725 jobs, the company said.

IRDAI moots public insurance registry

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) is proposing a Public Insurance Registry to consolidate insurance data across stakeholders, cut information asymmetry, improve fraud detection and enable data-driven regulatory oversight.

Crucial step

The proposed PIR is a crucial step towards modernising information architecture of the insurance sector, Chairman Ajay Seth told stakeholders discussion on PIR and e-market-place Bima Sugam organ-



New step: PIR is envisioned as consent-driven, legally compliant digital infrastructure covering policy lifecycle. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

ised by IRDAI at New Delhi.

IRDAI said the PIR is envisioned as a consent-driven, legally compliant digital infrastructure covering entire policy lifecycle from issuance to claims, grievance redressal and dispute resolution. It will be a

structured, interoperable information infrastructure.

Whole Time Member Deepak Sood spoke on the economic and business case of the PIR and the value proposition for all stakeholders.

Besides senior leader-

ship from insurers, invited stakeholders from the insurance ecosystem attended the meeting.

Key expectations from the insurance sector were discussed, including compliance readiness, data governance standards, cybersecurity safeguards and role of interoperable digital infrastructure in modernising the insurance ecosystem, IRDAI said in a release on the meeting.

The need for alignment between the PIR and Bima Sugam to enable seamless access to insurance policies, enhance service delivery, and redefine the overall customer experience was also discussed.

Ministry of Planning, Niti Aayog get House panel rap for ‘poor planning’ of finances

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance pulled up the Ministry of Planning for not “planning” its finances better. The committee found that despite spending less than half of the budget allocated to it, the Ministry was allocated ever-higher amounts over the past three financial years.

In its latest report tabled in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday, the committee called for “more realistic” planning and financial management by the Ministry. The government’s nodal think-tank, the Niti Aayog, operates through the Ministry.

The committee also noted “flaws in planning” by Niti Aayog when it comes to its finances.

Under-utilisation

“After overall scrutiny of estimates, allocations and utilisation of the budget grants during financial years under reference, the Committee are of the view that there has been continuous underutilisation of the earmarked funds by the Ministry of Planning,” the Standing Committee’s report said.

The committee noted that the Ministry sought ₹1,203.38 crore of funds for the upcoming financial year 2025-27, which is about 22% higher than the ₹1,006.06 crore as per the Budget Estimates (BE) for 2025-26.

“However, the Actuals for the FY 2023-24 were at ₹290.81 crore against a BE of ₹824.39 crore, which is around 35% of the BE,” the committee noted. “Likewise, the Actuals for the FY 2024-25 were only ₹282.61 crore, against a BE of ₹837.26 crore i.e. just about 34% in percentage terms.”

The committee noted that this situation seems to have improved in 2025-26 but also said that the actual utilisation amount is only slightly more than half the amount budgeted.

“With only a narrow window of two months remaining in the FY under reference, the Committee are not very optimistic,” it added.

The committee said that

The committee called for a “more realistic” financial management by the Ministry

despite this continuous under-utilisation, the BE of the Ministry grew 20% and 22%, respectively, in the preceding years.

“The Committee in their previous reports have time and again emphasised the need for more realistic planning and financial management for optimal use of available financial resources,” the report said.

“The Committee therefore strongly recommend Ministry of Planning to ensure that 2026-27 budget is utilised effectively and to avoid any idling and blocking of funds in the non-responsive Heads.”

“The Committee hope that the Ministry of Planning would be more fiscally prudent in assessment of their projected expenditure and targets in the future,” it added.

Dismal implementation

The committee said that its analysis of Niti Aayog’s Quarterly Expenditure Plan (QEP) reveals a “persistent and significant” underutilisation. The data in the report shows that, in 2023-24 and 2024-25, actual spending was approximately 35% and 33% of the total BE, respectively.

“This indicates flaws in planning as there is dismal implementation of the plans on the ground,” the Committee said. “While FY 2025-26 shows a positive trend with improved utilisation (56.46%), the surge in Q4 expenditure remains a concern.”

It said that a projected spending of ₹139.17 crore in Q4 of 2025-26 “appears to be a disproportionate rush to exhaust funds”, and also risks violating the Central government’s 15% monthly spending cap.

“The Committee are of the firm view that there is need to adhere to strict Quarterly Expenditure Percentage norms and NITI Aayog should conduct internal reviews to synchronise administrative sanctions with the QEP,” the report said.

Expedite pending, new gas pipeline projects, Centre tells States, UTs

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Centre has written to State governments and Union Territories, urging them to expedite disposal of pending applications for laying city gas distribution pipelines and approve new applications within 24 hours, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) told reporters here at an inter-ministerial briefing on Tuesday.

Ms. Sharma also informed that the Centre had urged the respective governments to waive road restoration and permission charges and relax working conditions, among others.

These actions are part of the government’s broader objective to create a supportive infrastructure to prompt consumers for a switch to piped natural gas (PNG), to ease pressure off liquefied petroleum gas (LPG).

According to data from the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), as of September end last year, it had authorised laying of approximately 34,200 km of natural gas pipelines. Of this, 25,293 km had been made operational with 9,954 km under construction.

Charges waived

The regulator said considering the “prevailing geopolitical crisis” it had decided to waive the imbalance charges applicable to relevant entities, shippers and consumers until June 30, with immediate effect.

“This waiver is being allowed as a temporary relief measure in light of the extraordinary circumstances arising out of the current geopolitical situation in the Gulf countries, which has adversely impacted supply conditions and operational balancing,” the notice read. “During the aforesaid period, no imbalance charges shall be levied on concerned entities/shipper in respect of gas scheduling/offtake/transportation/ balancing subject to compliance with all other terms and conditions, regulations, and operational requirements,” it added.

ଓଡ଼ିଶା ବିଦ୍ୟୁତ୍ ଶକ୍ତି

ସଂଚାରଣ ନିଗମ ଲିଡ଼

(ଓଡ଼ିଶା ସରକାରଙ୍କ ଏକ ଉପକ୍ରମ)

Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007



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NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

E-Tender No.	Tender Description:	Estimated Cost
CPC-69/2025-26	Bids are invited from reputed manufactures in two part bidding system for Lot-I: Supply of 310 Nos. of 132kV surge arrester. Lot-II: Supply of 450 Nos. of 33kV surge arrester. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 15.04.2026 upto 12:30 Hr.	Rs. 1,29,86,324.32/- Rs. 82,71,174.6/-
CPC-70/2025-26	Engineering, supply, Installation and Testing & commissioning works for “Construction of 220kV SC line in parallel to the existing line through underground cable for 400/220kV, 500MVA ICT at New-Duburi GSS” on Turnkey Contract Basis in e-tendering mode only. . Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 06.04.2026 upto 12:00 P.M.	Rs. 4,47,76,622/-

Complete set of bidding documents are available at www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL and www.optcl.co.in.
📞 📧 /optcl.odisha 📧 /optcl_odisha **HIPR-81/2025-26**

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Embargo-hit Cuba restores power in most parts after latest blackout



Petro points finger at Ecuador over bombing near Colombian border



South Sudan conflict pushes close to 100,000 into Ethiopia: UNICEF



U.S. counterterrorism chief resigns over Trump's Iran war, blames Israel

Israel strikes Tehran, Beirut; Baghdad's Green Zone hit

UN condemns displacement of Palestinians in West Bank

Trump asks China to delay Xi summit as Iran war rages

‘Kurds seek a democratic Iranian state; we do not fight other powers’ wars’

CM
YK

NO TWO WAYS ABOUT IT
‘First game is on March 31, we’ll ensure we play our last on May 31’



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Punjab Kings batter Shashank Singh is determined to help his team reach its second successive Indian Premier League final. “We know that we will be playing our first match on March 31 (against Gujarat Titans in New Chandigarh). We will make sure we play our season’s last match on May 31 (date of the summit clash),” said Shashank.

DOWN UNDER UP NORTH
Strong Australian presence in the Punjab Kings camp



FILE PHOTO

There will once again be a strong Australian presence in the PBKS camp. While Marcus Stoinis, Cooper Connolly (*in pic*), Mitchell Owen, Ben Dwarshuis and Xavier Bartlett are in the playing squad, head coach Ricky Ponting, assistant coach Brad Haddin and fast-bowling coach James Hopes belong to the backroom set-up.

BIG BLOW
KKR fast bowler Harshit set to miss major part of IPL 2026



FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

Kolkata Knight Riders pacer Harshit Rana is set to miss a major part of IPL 2026 after undergoing knee surgery last month. The 24-year-old, who suffered a knee strain during India’s T20 World Cup warm-up fixture against South Africa, is undergoing rehabilitation with no confirmation about his return by the BCCI medical team.

TRULY ADMIRABLE
Ashwin all praise for Gambhir’s team-over-individuals approach



FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

I like Gautam (Gambhir). Many people may have different opinions about him, but he is someone who always puts the team ahead of individuals. That is something I admire. There is more to Indian cricket than just a couple of people — R. Ashwin on Team India head coach Gambhir’s style of functioning.

Shreyas’ Kings have the firepower to go the distance

The Punjab willow-wielders are expected to stick to their slam-bang approach; the plethora of skilful all-rounders in the PBKS ranks will provide a happy headache for head coach Ponting

S. Shrivathsan

No leader from the Punjab Kings dynasty has conquered the Indian Premier League. Which is why Shreyas Iyer, the current chief of the PBKS army, had rallied his troops with a war cry moments after losing the final battle in the previous IPL tussle.

“The job is still half done. We have to lift the trophy next year,” Shreyas had said after being beaten to the crown by Royal Challengers Bengaluru skipper Rajat Patidar.

With the top prize again up for grabs in the upcoming iteration of the T20 league, Shreyas & Co. will enter the battleground with a single-minded focus on capturing PBKS’ maiden title.

Having retained the core of the crew that drove the team to the summit clash last season — 21 players were kept hold of while Pravin Dubey was bought back — the Punjab outfit has the resources to reign supreme.

Shreyas and head coach Ricky Ponting — the men who call the shots — are



Promising: Punjab Kings will have high expectations from its Indian talent. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

proponents of playing a fearless brand of cricket, so the batting wing is expected to stick to its slam-bang approach.

The willow-wielders, however, must pull out all stops to avoid the ‘second season syndrome’ after having raised the bar to take IPL 2025 by storm.

The captain will once again have to act as the glue that holds the batting contingent together, considering the lack of interna-

tional players it possesses — in a tournament where rivals take a yard when given an inch, top-level experience is like gold dust.

Shreyas may have to double up as an enforcer after the departure of Josh Inglis.

The challenge in front of him could be bigger than it appears since the 31-year-old has not been involved in enough high-quality action in the months leading up to the league.

Same is the case with leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal, the side’s biggest wicket-taking weapon and the most experienced member of the bowling band.

Chahal, who is the IPL’s chart-topper with 221 scalps, has been on the sidelines for a majority of the last four months, but the team would hope that he gets his mojo back to weave his middle-overs magic.

Left-arm pacer Arshdeep Singh could be another point of difference for the franchise that calls him ‘one of its own’.

All-rounders Marcus Stoinis, Azmatullah Omarzai, Marco Jansen and Harpreet Brar provide not only strength in batting depth but also a happy bowling selection headache.

To last the distance, the PBKS forces should fire on all cylinders.

Punjab Kings

FINALIST: 2014, 2025

BY OPPONENT

TEAM	M	W	L	NR
CSK	32	16	16	0
DC	34	17	17	0
GT	6	3	3	0
KKR	35	13	21	1
LSG	6	3	3	0
MI	34	17	17	0
RCB	37	18	19	0
RR	30	13	17	0
SRH	24	7	17	0

OVERALL NUMBERS

Matches

263

Won

122

Lost

140

NR

1

Punjab Kings’ remaining matches were against Deccan Chargers (10), PWI (6), GL (4), RPS (4) and KTK (1)

MIRACLE MAN

Shreyas Iyer

THE India international’s tactical acumen and batting mastery will be key to the Punjab side’s chances. His exemplary leadership skills will come in handy if and when the squad, comprising many uncapped players, wades through tough times during the season. The upgraded version of his batting game, which was on full display in the previous season, has been posing plenty of problems for opposition bowlers. In essence, PBKS does well when Shreyas does well.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & S. SHRIVATHSAN



Trust in team: Ponting and Shreyas will have the core of the crew that drove PBKS to the final last year. FILE PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

Irfan confident of Shreyas repeating last season’s heroics

ANI
MUMBAI

Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan has expressed optimism that Punjab Kings (PBKS) skipper Shreyas Iyer will be able to replicate his last season’s stupendous run in IPL 2026.

Irfan feels while there is a spot for Shreyas in the Indian T20I set-up, the right-hander is a “proven player” who does not need to use the IPL to present his case for a return to T20I team.

After PBKS’ runner-up finish last year, the expectations are high with Shreyas and head coach Ricky Ponting forming a powerful leadership duo.

Last season, Shreyas finished as his side’s top run-getter and overall sixth-highest with 604 runs in 17 innings at an average of 50.33 and a strike rate of 175.07, including six fifties. Having won the IPL with

Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) as captain in 2024 and after taking PBKS to the final, Shreyas is one cracking season away from a potential return to India’s T20I set-up.

Speaking on *JioHotstar*, Irfan pointed out how “Shreyas has improved by leaps and bounds”.

“I am not sure that Shreyas would be thinking of using the IPL as a stage to prove himself for a comeback into the T20I side. Shreyas is a proven player. He has done really well in T20 cricket for Punjab Kings and has done really well for Team India as well. He is a very important player in one-day cricket. I think there is a place for him in the T20I set-up and he is aware of that.

“He has improved by leaps and bounds. I am really excited to see if he can replicate the same performance this season as well. I am confident he will,” said Irfan.

Jayawardene eager to witness Rohit’s ‘newer version’ in action

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

Rohit Sharma may not have featured in T20 cricket for nearly a year, but as he gears up for another Indian Premier League season, Mumbai Indians head coach Mahela Jayawardene is expecting a “newer version” of the veteran opener.

“He (Rohit) has done a lot of work behind the scenes. He had a lot of skill work done in the last week. He joined us on the first day of our training camp. He looked very good in the nets. This is a newer version of Rohit as well — much fitter — and very committed. So, I’m looking forward to him leading us from the top,” Jayawardene said on the sidelines of the final of the MI Junior on Tuesday.

Rohit, who retired from T20Is in 2024 after leading India to the ICC Men’s T20 World Cup title, remains a key figure for MI. In IPL 2025, he scored 418 runs in 15 matches.

Meanwhile, the head coach isn’t concerned about India’s T20 World Cup-winning captain Suryakumar Yadav’s form. Despite the team’s success, Suryakumar endured a relatively quiet campaign, scoring 242 runs in the global showpiece. “SKY is not worried too much about his form. He’s a class operator,” Jayawardene said.

“He’s always going to get there. He contributed



Stronger and sharper: Jayawardene says Rohit is much fitter and very committed. X@MIPALTAN

when it mattered. Yes, consistency is something that he would want to improve. But leading the team the way he led the team [was incredible]. There were a couple of tough decisions they had to make during the season and in the World Cup, which SKY did. Hats off to him. I’m sure

he’ll have a good break and join the camp with a smiling face,” he said.

While interacting with the youngsters after the final, Jayawardene said: “This is something we thrive on, scouting young boys and girls. This year, too, we have identified some really good talent”.

RBI women stun PSPB for their third title in four years

TABLE TENNIS
Amol Karhadkar
INDORE

The Petroleum Sports Promotion Board (PSPB) men’s team clinched its 24th consecutive title, defeating West Bengal in the final of the 87th inter-State and senior National table tennis championship, sponsored by Ultimate Table Tennis, on Tuesday.

However, the highlight of the day was the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) women’s team scripting a remarkable comeback to edge past PSPB in a thrilling final at the Abhay Prashal Indoor Stadium, securing its third title in four years. In a contest that lasted over three hours, Sreeja Akula — India’s highest-ranked paddler — defeated Yashaswini Ghorpade in the deciding fifth game of the final rubber to seal the victory.

PSPB had looked set for a double when Taneesha Kotecha stunned Sreeja in the opening match, and Yashaswini comfortably beat Ayhika Mukherjee to give her team a 2-0 lead.

Diya Chitale, the reigning National champion, found herself trailing 1-6 in the second game against teenager Syndrela Das after losing the opener. However, Diya turned the tide with aggressive play, countering Syndrela’s sidespin returns to keep RBI in contention. Ayhika then le-



All smiles: The victorious RBI squad, including Diya, Nikhat, Ayhika, Priyadarshini, coach Chiranjeev Deka and Sreeja, pose for a selfie after receiving its winnings. AMOL KARHADKAR

velled the tie by dominating Taneesha to force a decider. In the final match, Sreeja held her nerve, unleashing her trademark down-the-line forehand topspin winners at crucial moments to clinch the title.

The men’s final, as expected, was largely one-sided. However, veteran Harmeet Desai was tested by left-hander Bodhisatwa Chaudhury. After leading 2-0 and 9-3, Harmeet appeared to lose focus, conceding eight consecutive points to drop the game. Bodhisatwa carried the momentum forward to level the match at two games apiece, but Harmeet’s experience ultimately prevailed as he won the decider to secure both the match and PSPB’s title.

The individual events began late on Tuesday evening, with Swastika Ghosh pulling out of the ca-

tegory due to medical reasons.

The results: Team Championship final: Men: PSPB bt West Bengal 3-0 (Payas Jain bt Ankur Bhattacharjee 12-10, 11-4, 1-11, 11-9; Manav Thakkar bt Aniket Sen Choudhury 15-13, 11-5, 11-5; Harmeet Desai bt Bodhisatwa Chaudhury 11-4, 11-2, 9-11, 6-11, 11-8).

Positions three to 10: Telangana, Railways Sports Promotion Board, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Assam, Delhi, Gujarat, and Punjab.

Women: RBI bt PSPB 3-2 (Sreeja Akula lost to Taneesha Kotecha 12-10, 12-10, 7-11, 13-15, 4-11; Ayhika Mukherjee lost to Yashwini Ghorpade 7-11, 5-11, 8-11, Diya Chitale bt Syndrela Das 12-14, 12-10, 11-7, 14-12, Ayhika bt Taneesha 11-7, 11-4, 11-5; Sreeja bt Yashaswini 11-5, 4-11, 11-9, 12-14, 11-6).

Positions three to 10: Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Delhi, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, West Bengal, and Haryana.

INBRIEF



FIFA signs ‘game-changing partnership’ with YouTube

YouTube made a World Cup deal with FIFA on Tuesday that lets rights-holding broadcasters stream game action live on the video platform that offers global access to young viewers. FIFA announced a “game-changing partnership” that encourages World Cup rights holders to broadcast the first 10 minutes of games during the June 11-July 19 tournament – in effect an appetiser encouraging young fans then to watch on traditional channels such as network TV. In addition, broadcasters “will be able to stream a select number of matches in full on their YouTube channel, engaging global audiences and promoting where to watch more of the competition,” FIFA said.

Contract with Brazilian team set to be extended: Ancelotti

National coach Carlo Ancelotti said the Brazilian Football Confederation is set to extend his contract till 2030 World Cup. He took over Brazil last May to the 2026 World Cup, and said neither he nor CBF “have any issues to extend the deal”.

Four more race days added to Hyderabad Winter Season

The Stewards Of the Hyderabad Race Club (HRC), at their meeting held on Tuesday (March 17), have resolved to include four more race days to the Hyderabad Winter Season 2025-26. The dates are: March 28 and 31 and April 4 and 5.

Wolves’ fightback frustrates Brentford

The away team, almost certainly on its way for relegation, shows tremendous spirit in coming back from two goals down to dent the host’s chances of making the Champions League

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Wolves staged an impressive fightback from two goals down against Brentford as the Premier League’s bottom club rescued a 2-2 draw thanks to Tolu Arokodare’s late equaliser on Monday. Rob Edwards’ side trailed to goals from Michael Kayode and Igor Thiago at the Gtech Community Stadium. But Adam Armstrong got one back just before half-time and Nigeria striker Arokodare snatched Wolves’ leveller in the closing stages.

Wolves is unbeaten in its last three league games following its shock wins over Aston Villa and Liverpool. It remains almost certain to be relegated, sitting 12 points from safety with only seven games left. But if Wolves does slip into the Championship, it can take heart from its refusal to go down with a whimper. “It’s hard to say when you’ve been 2-0 down but I felt we could have won the game,” Edwards said. “It shows the fight, the



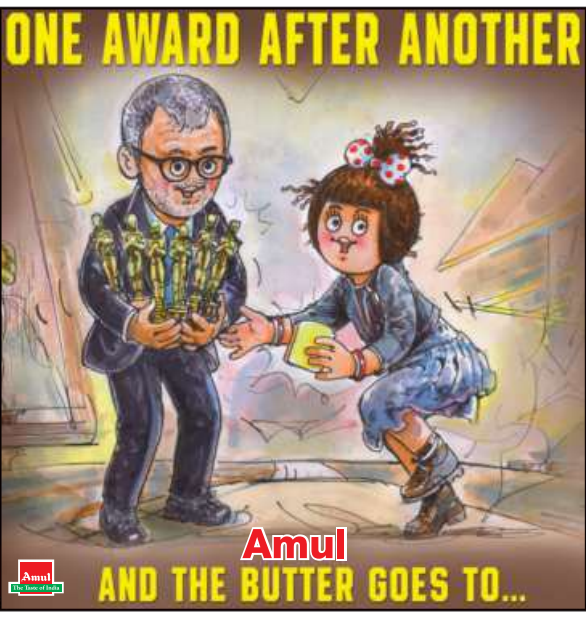
Drawing level: Arokodare, second right, scores Wolves’ second against Brentford. AP

courage, the quality, the spirit that’s in the group. “Even though we’re in this position, it actually feels united together.” It was a painful result for seventh-placed Brentford, which blew the chance to bolster its unexpected bid to qualify for Europe. Keith Andrews’ men are three points behind sixth-placed Chelsea and four adrift of fifth-placed Liverpool after failing to secure a win that would have catapulted them into contention for a Champions League place.

Tipped as relegation candidates at the start of this season, Brentford have enjoyed a remarkable campaign after losing manager Thomas Frank and forwards Bryan Mbeumo and Yoanne Wissa last summer. But in the space of seven days it has crashed out of the FA Cup at lowly West Ham and squandered a strong position against Wolves to endanger its memorable season. “When you’re talking about us in the same breath as Chelsea, that’s obviously pretty good con-

sidering there’s only eight games left,” Andrews said. “But the reality is we could have produced more tonight. “We need to be honest with that and look at ourselves.”

The results: Premier League: Brentford 2 (Kayode 22, Thiago 37) drew with Wolves 2 (Armstrong 44, Arokodare 77). **LaLiga:** Rayo Vallecano 1 (Ciss 90+4) drew with Levante 1 (Espí 41). **Serie A:** Cremonese 1 (Okereke 57) lost to Fiorentina 4 (Parisi 25, Piccoli 32, Dodo 49, Gudmundsson 70).



Iran negotiating with FIFA to move its World Cup games from the U.S. to Mexico

Agencies
MEXICO CITY

Iran’s Embassy in Mexico on Tuesday said the country is negotiating with FIFA to move Iran’s World Cup matches from the U.S. to Mexico after President Donald Trump discouraged the team from attending the tournament, citing safety concerns. It was unclear whether such talks are happening with FIFA, which did not immediately respond to requests for comment. Iranian officials have previously said it is up to FIFA and the U.S. to keep the team safe during the

World Cup. The Embassy posted a statement attributed to Iranian football federation president Mehdi Taj saying Iran wants to move its group-stage matches to Mexico to ensure the safety of players and officials. “We are currently negotiating with FIFA to hold Iran’s matches in the World Cup in Mexico,” the statement said.

Mexico ready to host Meanwhile, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum said that her country would have no problem hosting Iran’s matches if FIFA agrees.

Meenakshi stuns Antim at Asian C’ships trials



Meenakshi after defeating Antim. PTI

WRESTLING

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two-time World Championships medalist Antim Panghal suffered a shock defeat to Meenakshi at the selection trials and eventual exclusion from the side for the Asian Wrestling Championships at the Indira Gandhi indoor stadium here on Tuesday. Antim, who has virtually dominated the 53kg for the past couple of years, was pinned by Meenakshi in the final of the trials after breezing through the opening rounds without dropping a point, as did

her opponent. But the 25-year-old Meenakshi was confident, playing to her strengths and not allowing Antim to attack. The two were tied 2-2 in the first period before Meenakshi managed a couple of take-downs to race ahead 6-2. With seconds left, she pushed Antim’s shoulders to the mat to win by Fall. In the 76kg final, Kajal Dhochak continued her impressive form from the Pro Wrestling League to beat favourite Priya Malik 4-2. Other categories, meanwhile, went as per expectations with Manisha Bhanwala, defending champion in the 62kg, moving down two categories to win in

57kg, and Mansi Ahlawat (62kg) booking their respective berths. In Lucknow, the men’s trials were on more predictable lines except for Paris Olympics bronze medalist Aman Sehrawat participating and winning in the non-Olympic 61kg category, moving up from the 57kg. In his absence, Anush took the top spot in the 57kg. Meanwhile, four men and women each across categories have also been selected for the Asian Beach Games in Sanya, China, next month.

The squads: Men: Freestyle: Ankush (57kg), Aman Sehrawat (61kg), Sujeet Kalkal (65kg),

Abhimanyu (70kg), Jaideep (74kg), Sandeep Mann (79kg), Mukul Dahiya (86kg), Punit Kumar (92kg), Vicky (97kg), Dinesh Shankar (125kg). **Greco-Roman:** Lalit (55kg), Sahil (60kg), Sunny (63kg), Sachin Sehrawat (67kg), Anil (72kg), Aman (77kg), Prince (82kg), Sunil Kumar (87kg), Nitesh (97kg), Joginder Rathi (130kg). **Women:** Neelam Sirohi (50kg), Meenakshi (53kg), Hanshika Lamba (55kg), Manisha Bhanwala (57kg), Neha Sangwan (59kg), Mansi Ahlawat (62kg), Monika (65kg), Mansi Lather (68kg), Harshitha (72kg), Kajal Dhochak (76kg). **ABG squad: Men:** Siddharth (70kg), Amit (80kg), Aryan (90kg), Jaspooran Singh (90+kg). **Women:** Priyanshi Prajapat (50kg), Pushpa Yadav (60kg), Jaspreet Kaur (70kg), Priya Malik (70+kg).

RACING

HYDERABAD: Trainer G. Sandeep’s ward Vyasa, ridden by A. Ashad Asbar, won the Onnu Onnu Plate (Div. I), the main event of Tuesday’s (Mar. 17) races. The winner is owned by Mr. G.V. Reddy. **1. NARAYANPET PLATE (DIV. I) (1,400M):** DILIGENCE (Kuldeep Singh Sr.) 1, Red Hot Punch (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Fox Worth (P. Sai K) 3 and La Quinta (Suraj Narredo) 4. Not run: Marissa. 1-1/4, Head and 1. Im, 05.93s. ₹36 (w), 14, 19 and 54 (p). SHP: 45, THP: 166, FP: 202, Q: 164, Tanala: 2,993. Favourite: La Quinta. Owners: M/s. Cyrus S. Poonawalla & Adar C. Poonawalla rep. Villoo Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: Laxman Singh. **2. FLIRTING VISION PLATE (1,200M):** N R I RANGE (Afroz Khan) 1, Knotty Senorita (P. Sai K) 2, Dream To Fly (G. Nareesh) 3 and Smart Boy (B.R. Kumar) 4. 1, 6-1/2 and 2. Im, 12.87s. ₹31 (w), 13, 18 and 16 (p). SHP: 39, THP: 42, FP: 118, Q: 55, Tanala: 233. Favourite: Knotty Senorita. Owners: M/s. Krishnan Kamesh,

Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: M. Srinivas Reddy. **3. ONNU ONNU PLATE (DIV. I) (1,400M):** VYASA (A. Ashad Asbar) 1, Lucky Zone (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Pacific Heights (Ajay K) 3 and Leather Back (Rafique Sk.) 4. 13-1/2, 1 and 3/4. Im, 23.76s. ₹16 (w), 11, 20 and 31 (p). SHP: 58, THP: 47, FP: 101, Q: 98, Tanala: 1,019. Favourite: Vyasa. Owner: Mr. G.V. Reddy. Trainer: G. Sandeep. **4. MOSSY BANK PLATE (1,400M):** BHAIRAVA (P. Ajeeth K) 1, Rival (Suraj Narredo) 2, Clefairy (P. Sai K) 3 and Hoping Star (D.S. Deora) 4. Not run: Bholi Punjaban. Short Head, 3-1/4 and 7-1/2. Im, 24.95s. ₹17 (w), 11, 13 and 18 (p). SHP: 38, THP: 41, FP: 41, Q: 27, Tanala: 82. Favourite: Bhairava. Owner: Mr. T. Rakesh Reddy. Trainer: Ananth Vatsalya. **5. HYDERABAD PLATE (1,000M):** KNOTTY CIRCUIT (P. Sai K) 1, Divine Star (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Fugo (Trevor) 3 and Anemara (B.R. Kumar) 4. 1-1/2, 2-1/2 and 1-1/2. Im, 05.91s. ₹26 (w), 10, 11 and 14 (p). SHP: 46, THP: 32, FP: 113, Q: 69, Tanala: 249. Favourite: Knotty Circuit. Owners: M/s. Krishnan Kamesh,

K. Balamukunda Das, Manoj Krishnappa Kumar, Srikanth Badraka & Dharmesh Mehta. Trainer: A. Imran Khan. **6. ONNU ONNU PLATE (DIV. II) (1,400M):** NORTHERN WAVES (Suraj Narredo) 1, Cherie Chevalier (Antony Raj) 2, Secret Saint (Trevor) 3 and Arabeska (Akshay K) 4. 1-1/4, 3-1/2 and 4. Im, 24.47s. ₹17 (w), 10, 12 and 28 (p). SHP: 41, THP: 57, FP: 50, Q: 34, Tanala: 146. Favourite: Northern Waves. Owner: Mr. V. Narendar Reddy. Trainer: G. Shashikanth. **7. NARAYANPET PLATE (DIV. II) (1,000M):** AUTHORITARIAN (Ajay Kumar) 1, Ek (Afroz K) 2, My Honey (Kuldeep Sr.) 3 and Catchme If You Can (D.S. Deora) 4. 2, 2-1/2 and 6-3/4. Im 05.75s. ₹12 (w), 10, 22 and 27 (p). SHP: 34, THP: 57, FP: 59, Q: 44, Tanala: 227. Favourite: Authoritarian. Owners: Mr. Cyrus F. Palia & Kunwar Digvijay Singh Shekhawat. Trainer: Laxman Singh. Jackpot: 70%: ₹527 (882 tkts.), 30%: 129 (1,544 tkts.). Mini Jackpot: (i) 657 (125 tkts.), (ii) 339 (307 tkts.). Treble: (i) 134 (113 tkts.), 107 (386 tkts.).

Neymar misses out as Endrick returns to Brazil squad

Agence France-Presse
RIO DE JANEIRO

Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti said on Monday Neymar is “not 100% ” fit so will miss two friendlies later this month as youngster Endrick returns to the squad. Santos’ Neymar has not played for Brazil since October 2023 due to a serious knee injury but has played four games for his club since mid-February. The 34-year-old misses out on pre-World Cup friendlies against France on March 27 in Boston and Croatia four days later in Orlando. Brazil starts its bid for a sixth World Cup title, but first since 2002, against Morocco in New Jersey on June 13, before also facing Haiti and Scotland in Group C. “I haven’t called him up because he’s not 100%,” Ancelotti told reporters. “But for the final (World Cup) squad, that’s another story,” the 66-year-old added. Real Madrid forward Rodrygo and Newcastle



Back in business: Endrick’s uptick in form sees him making the squad for Brazil’s friendlies. AFP

midfielder Bruno Guimaraes are sidelined through injury. Endrick, 19, made the last of his 14 international appearances a year ago. But he earned a recall thanks to an impressive string of performances since joining Lyon on loan from Real Madrid. Ancelotti brought Endrick to the Santiago Bernabeu in 2024 from Palmeiras. The Italian has selected two uncapped players in Brentford striker Igor Thiago and Bournemouth teenager Rayan.

The squad: Goalkeepers:

Alisson (Liverpool), Bento (Al-Nassr), Ederson (Fenerbahce). **Defenders:** Alex Sandro (Flamengo), Bremer (Juventus), Danilo (Flamengo), Douglas Santos (Zenith Saint-Petersburg), Gabriel Magalhaes (Arsenal), Ibanez (Al-Ahli), Leo Pereira (Flamengo), Marquinhos (PSG), Wesley (Roma). **Midfielders:** Andrey Santos (Chelsea), Casemiro (Manchester United), Danilo (Botafogo), Fabinho (Al-Ittihad), Gabriel Sara (Galarasaray). **Forwards:** Endrick (Lyon), Gabriel Martinelli (Arsenal), Igor Thiago (Brentford), Joao Pedro (Chelsea), Luiz Henrique (Zenith Saint-Petersburg), Matheus Cunha (Manchester United), Raphinha (Barcelona), Rayan (Bournemouth), Vinicius Jr (Real Madrid).

Hockey WC: India and Pakistan men in same group

Sports Bureau
HYDERABAD

India is set to reignite its storied rivalry with Pakistan after both sides were drawn together in Pool D of the FIH men’s Hockey World Cup 2026 during Tuesday’s draw in Amsterdam. England and Wales complete the group. In the women’s section, India is in Pool D along with China, England, and South Africa. Both the men’s and women’s tournaments will be jointly hosted by Belgium and the Netherlands, from August 15 to 30. **The pools: Men: A:** Netherlands, Argentina, New Zealand, Japan; **B:** Belgium, Germany, France, Malaysia; **C:** Australia, Spain, Ireland, South Africa; **D:** England, India, Pakistan, Wales. **Women: A:** Netherlands, Australia, Chile, Japan. **B:** Argentina, Germany, USA, Scotland. **C:** Belgium, Spain, New Zealand, Ireland; **D:** China, England, India, South Africa.

AROUND THE CITY

Kamalini’s unbeaten 151 puts Tamil Nadu in the semifinal G. Kamalini’s unbeaten 151 (118b, 9x4, 7x6) helped Tamil Nadu beat Delhi by six wickets (VJD method) in the BCCI women’s u-23 One-Day Trophy quarterfinal in Ranchi on Tuesday. **The scores: Elite, quarterfinals:** Delhi 288/5 in 50 overs (Deeksha Sharma 64, Upasana Yadav 45, Tanisha Singh 92 n.o.) lost to TNadu 255/4 in 42.1 overs (G. Kamalini 151 n.o., Neha Yuvaraj 49 n.o.). *TN won by VJD method.*

Sunil scalps five in Guru Nanak’s win Off-spinner N. Sunil Krishna took five for 17 to set up Guru Nanak’s 10-wicket win over MVIT (Puducherry) in a men’s Pool-A match of the 12th Pavit Singh Nayar all-India inter-collegiate T20 tournament on Tuesday. **The scores: Men: Pool-A:** A.M. Jain 167 in 19.4 overs (V. Sathyannarayanan 38, G.M. Gokul 70, S. Guru Prasath 3/34, E. Anbu Mani 3/33, S. Subash 3/24) lost to KSR (Thiruchengode) 168/3 in 19.1 overs (V. Anovankar 54, A.P. Anandha Kumar 37, Sachin Saravanan 30 n.o.).



Kamalini (TN, 151 n.o.); Sunil Krishna (Guru Nanak, 5/17).

MVIT (Puducherry) 84/9 in 20 overs (N. Sunil Krishna 5/17) lost to Guru Nanak 85 for no loss in nine overs (L.R. Navin 51 n.o., B. Sachin 33 n.o.). **Pool-B:** Pillai (Mumbai) 79 in 17.3 overs (R. Yeswanth Kumar 3/18, M. Subash Chandra Bose 4/8) lost to Pachaiyappa’s 82/1 in 6 overs (P. Kannan 36, S. Aryan 40 n.o.). Kongu Arts & Science (Erode) 208/4 in 20 overs (M. Kishore Kumar 93, I. Dharunesh 66 n.o.) bt SMVEC (Puducherry) 184/6 in 20 overs (G. Sunil 37, R. Akash Aravind 85, S. Aathi Lingam 3/26). **Pool-C:** Guru Nanak-B 165/3 in 20 overs (S. Sachin Sredev 61, Akshay R. Sarangdhar 59 n.o.) bt Gobi Arts & Science 142/8 in 20 overs (S.P. Ragul Rithick 46, B. Sachin 44). KPR (Coimbatore) 104 in 19.1 overs (R. Sree Shivaji 51, B. Aaditya 3/17, S. Lakshay Jain 4/15) lost to RKM Vivekananda 108/2 in 12.3 overs (Abhinav Kannan 52, K.V. Raaghav 32 n.o.). **Pool-D:** TKR (Hyderabad) 128/9 in 20 overs (Aryan Krishna 34, K. Karthik Rahul 4/19) lost to Sri Ramakrishna CAS (Coimbatore) 129/1 in 8.3 overs (G. Ajitesh 66

n.o., S. Vinay 55 n.o.). CKT (Mumbai) 106/9 in 20 overs (Prathamesh Rane 37 n.o., Siddarth Prakash 3/16) lost to Loyola 107/3 in 10.1 overs. **Women:** MGR Janaki 47 in 16.4 overs lost to Guru Nanak-A 50 for no loss in four overs. Ethiraj 174/1 in 20 overs (R. Sri Devi 72 n.o., A. Varshini 38, S. Pavithra 39 n.o.) bt DKM (Vellore) 75 in 19 overs (S. Pavithra 3/20, P. Karuna 4/10); Sri Ramakrishna CAS (Coimbatore) 178/3 in 20 overs (S. Sweata 59, S. Vaishnaavi 55) bt KSR (Thiruchengode) 93/2 in 20 overs (G. Rashitha Shasha Mary 45); JBAS 109/9 in 20 overs (Haridha Sri 4/14) lost to Guru Nanak-B 110/1 in 18.1 overs (M. Arshiya 53 n.o.).

LIVE TELECAST

Squash: Indian Open, FanCode, 12.45 p.m. **Europe League:** Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 9 p.m. **Champions League:** Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m.; Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 1.30 a.m. (Thursday)

ENGAGEMENTS

Golf: TNGF Premier League, round four, chief guests, former CSK cricketers Murali Vijay and Anirudha Srikanth, TNGF Cosmo Golf Club (Nandanam), 1.30 p.m.

Indian Open squash to feature a strong mix of Indian and intl. stars

Sports Bureau

The second edition of the JSW Indian Open will begin at the CCI Brabourne Stadium in Mumbai on Wednesday. Recognised by the Professional Squash Association (PSA) and held under the aegis of the Squash Rackets Federation of India (SRFI), the tournament will witness a strong mix of top Indian and international players. **Focus on Anahat** The focus will be on top seed and defending champion Anahat Singh. Joshna Chinappa, Ramit Tandon, Veer Chotrani and Abhay Singh are the other Indians who will look to make an impact. Among the international players, Yahya Elnawasnay, Nadien Elhammam and Enora Villard will be watched with interest.

INTERVIEW

Ramit Tandon

K. Keerthivasan

After a frustrating build-up to the 2022 Asian Games that ultimately cost him a place in the Indian team, Ramit Tandon has quietly rebuilt his rhythm and belief. Now ranked World No. 37 and coming off a strong start to the season, the 34-year-old is looking ahead with renewed clarity – targeting a return to the Asian Games stage and a deeper push on the PSA Tour.

On the eve of the JSW Indian Open in Mumbai, where he is seeded third, Tandon spoke to *The Hindu* about form, fitness, the evolving Indian squash landscape, and the road to a crucial year for the sport. Excerpts:

Your best result playing at home was reaching the semifinals at the CCI International, a PSA World Tour silver event, in 2019. Going into the the JSW Indian Open, how are you feeling?

It's always wonderful playing at home. The issue is we don't get to do it as frequently, but obviously with squash making it to the [2028 Los Angeles] Olympics, we are seeing a big boost. A couple of months ago, there was a massive event in Indore as well, at Daly College. Last year, the JSW Indian Open was the first glasscourt event after a gap

of a few years. I think post COVID, Indore tournament was the first time they (organisers) hosted an event. And now it's a yearly affair. It's always a good feeling to play in front of people who have supported you through your career, those familiar faces and of course, the home support. It's hard to beat that.

At the Indian Open, you will be the third seed, behind Abhay Singh (second) and Egypt's Yahya Elnawasany. What are your expectations?

Being the third seed, obviously, I would like to do well at the event. And I would love to hopefully go back home with the trophy. At the same time, you also have to take it one step at a time and be patient. It's important not to get carried away with rankings. They are just a number. Anyone can beat anyone as there are a lot of upsets happening in the PSA Tour worldwide. My approach will be to enjoy my week in Mumbai and play my best squash.

You have spent much part of your time competing in USA training and sparring with top players...

I train with former World No. 1 David Palmer, who is now based in Utica in upstate New York. Then apart from that, when the season starts, there's not much training that we can do as you don't get much time since we are competing every other week. At that point in time, it just becomes a question of putting yourself in areas where there are enough players where you can continuously get sparring practice. So, a good chunk of my time has been in the USA. I am already in India (Kolkata now) getting used to the weather here, because it's very different from the winters in America. I'm trying to get used to the climate here.

Tell us about the Indian squash landscape as far as the men are concerned?

I think Indian men's squash is obviously at a very strong point. I can't remember the last time we had four players ranked in the world's top 50. We have been a dominant force. Back in the day, there was always Saurav Ghosal, who was extremely good. He was in the top 10 (in 2019), but he didn't have a backup. The other players back then were probably outside the 50s, 60s in the world. And the way squash is these days, it's like there's a difference in ranking, but there's not much of a difference in level.

For example, when you're saying someone is in the top 30, top 40, or top 50 in the world, it's not surprising if you see them beat those in the top 20 or top 10. From a perspective of where we can go as a nation, I believe there is a lot of scope and potential for Indian squash on the men's side in the way it has shown itself as a unit and as a team. Having said that, it's also pressure to get it right. I feel

All our scheduling is going to revolve around peaking for the Asian Games

From training bases in the United States to competing at home in Mumbai, Tandon is balancing preparation and performance. The Indian men's No. 2 shares insights on life on tour and discusses his Asian Games ambitions, the depth in Indian squash, and the challenge of breaking into the world's elite

like as a country, we need to take the right steps to make sure we groom the players in the right way so that they break into the world's top 10 and come back with medals from the world championship and other big events.

Do you think that is possible?

We are not in England, France, or Egypt where we have world champions in the past. No one has done it. It's a bit of unknown territory for us. But with the support of corporates and with squash being added to TOPS scheme, I'm sure we can put together a plan that will see us maximise our potential.

With the Asian Games coming up this year, how keen are you to be part of the Indian men's team?

Asian Games is the biggest event for us this year. India has always been a strong contender at the Asian Games. As the

defending champion in men's team, we would be keen to do well. All our scheduling is going to revolve around how to peak for the Asian Games. I am excited and looking forward to it. The last Asian Games in 2022 was a little tricky. I had a few injuries leading up to the Games and a few issues with rankings and selection policies and a bit of back injury that kind of ruled me out of the Games eventually. Of course, stakes are high because the Olympic qualification is on line the singles (men and women) winner will qualify for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

At the moment, you are ranked 37 in the world. How difficult is it to maintain the ranking for you to be in the team at this stage for the Asian Games?

I don't know what the selection format or

the policies are for this year's Asian Games. As of today, I would say the four boys in the world's top 50 in the world should be the ones at the Asian Games.

Will there be a selection trials for the Asian Games?

We have received information on selection trials and training camp for the Indian team in Chennai in June. But there's still no clarity on the exact process that will be followed.

Squash is making its debut at the 2028 Olympics. Who do you think will make the cut for it?

It's the Olympics. It's supposed to be difficult, right? There's nothing easy when it comes to playing the Olympics. When you look at the world rankings changing every week, it gives every player a lot of opportunities to move up



I think Indian men's squash is obviously at a very strong point. I can't remember the last time we had four players ranked in the world's top 50. We have been a dominant force. Back in the day, there was always Saurav Ghosal, who was extremely good. He was in the top 10 (in 2019), but he didn't have a backup



There's nothing easy when it comes to playing the Olympics. When you look at the world rankings changing every week, it gives every player a lot of opportunities to move up the rankings. Apart from that, there's going to be the Asian qualification, which is the Asian Games. Then, there's going to be an eventual world qualification, which would be after removing all the players who have qualified

the rankings. Apart from that, there's going to be the Asian qualification, which is the Asian Games. Then, there's going to be an eventual world qualification, which would be after removing all the players who have qualified. As of now, anyone, for me, in the top 50 in the world stands a chance to make the cut for the Olympics.

Having said that, the nature of our sport with injuries and with how the game is structured, even the best player in the world today might lose his/her spot at the Olympics.

You did pretty well to reach the quarterfinals of the Motor City Open. How are you feeling heading into the Indian Open?

I'm happy with the level I'm playing. The Motor City Open was a good run for me. And I'm looking forward to this patch of events because I haven't played this season. After Motor City, I was supposed to play in the Texas Open, but I fell sick and I haven't competed in any event since. I'm looking forward to the Indian Open, following which that I have a packed calendar.

Do you think India should host more big events?

We are definitely seeing an increase in the number of PSA events in our country. I think we should consider hosting one or two major events every year. I do understand the requirement of smaller events as well because there are a lot of other players who are not in world's top 50, who need that support to climb up in the rankings. Perhaps, a blend of maybe three events a year, a PSA Copper, Bronze, and above [Gold and Platinum] level will really benefit the higher ranked players. At least, India is bringing the world circuit and, the challenge for me and the other players in the country is to go deep in bigger tournaments.

Anahat Singh is the toast of nation as far as squash is concerned. How do you see the 17-year-old's meteoric rise?

Anahat has been exceptional. I think what she's achieved in general is exceptional for her age. If you look at Anahat's ranking a year ago (WR 62) and you look at where she's today (WR 20), it's a massive, massive difference. If she just continues the way she's doing, I hope she can break a lot more records.

Cholesterol makes cells’ nuclei squishy, helping melanoma spread

When cholesterol levels in the nuclear envelope were high, the nucleus became easier to deform; this is important because cancer cells often have to squeeze through tight gaps between other cells to spread and a squishier nucleus makes that squeezing easier, so the cancer can invade new tissues more successfully

D.P. Kasbekar

Melanoma is one of the most dangerous common skin cancers. It starts in melanocytes, the skin cells that make melanin, the pigment that gives skin its colour.

Cancer doesn’t appear overnight. A normal cell becomes cancerous in steps, as its DNA and its gene-control systems pick up changes over time. These changes push the cell to do three things: divide too much, avoid being destroyed by the immune system, and spread into other parts of the body. This spread is called metastasis, and it is what makes many cancers deadly.

Researchers want to know which changes matter most because those changes can become targets for treatment.

Becoming squishy

A recent study led by scientists at the U.S. National Institutes of Health reported an unexpected driver of cancer spread: cholesterol in the membrane around the cell nucleus. The nucleus is the cell’s control room, where most of the DNA is stored. It’s wrapped in a thin nuclear envelope, like a flexible shell.

The team found this pattern in melanoma and also in breast and prostate cancers. When cholesterol levels in the nuclear envelope were high, the nucleus became easier to deform. In other words, it became more squishy. This is important because cancer cells often have to squeeze through tight gaps between other cells to spread. A squishier nucleus makes that squeezing easier, so the cancer can invade new tissues more successfully.

High cholesterol did something else, too: it made the nuclear envelope more fragile. Fragile envelopes were more likely to tear in small, local spots. When a tear happens, the DNA inside can be exposed to forces that damage it. Damaged DNA can lead to new mutations, and some of those new mutations can make the cancer even more aggressive.

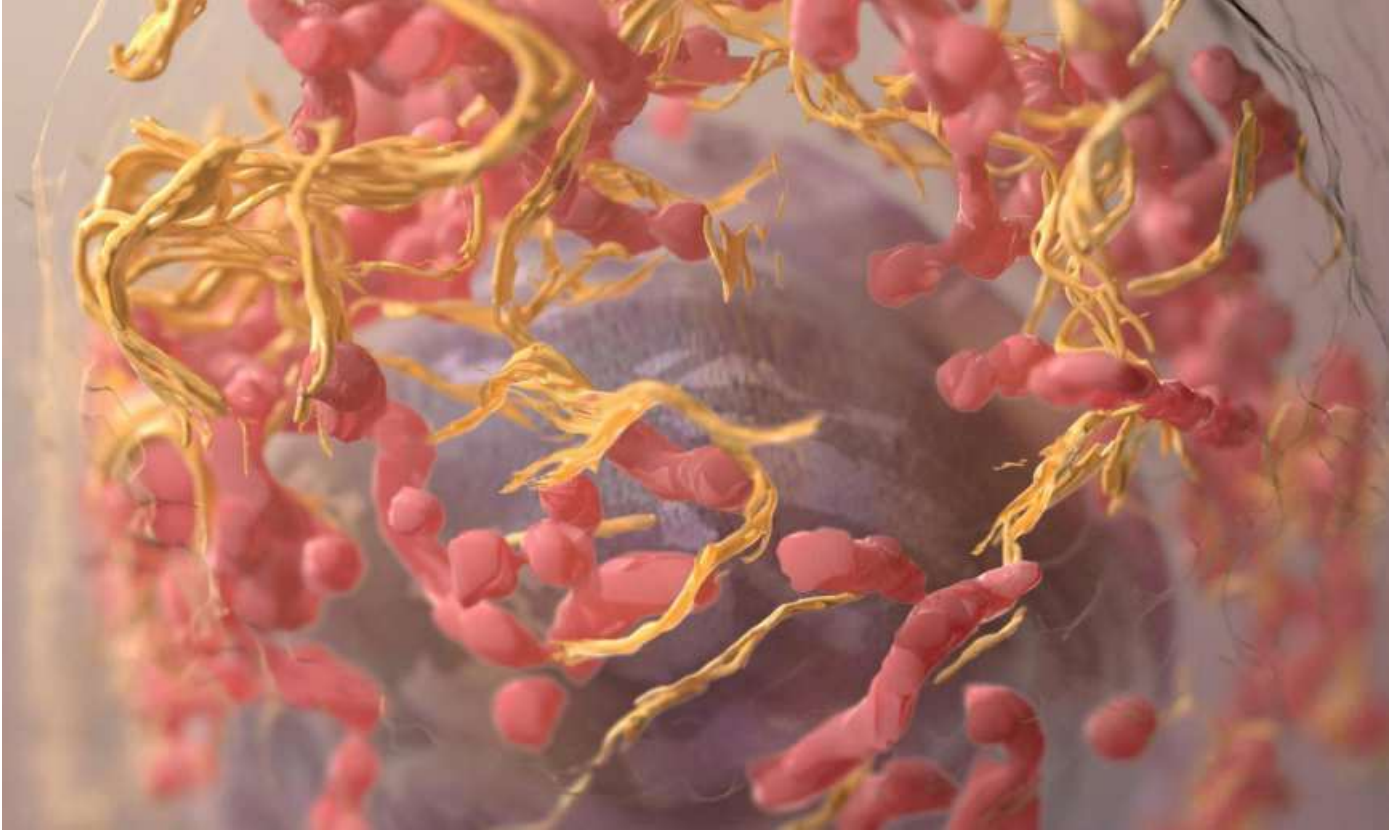
When the researchers lowered cholesterol levels in cancer cells, the cells became less invasive and less aggressive.

These findings also help explain an earlier observation: people with melanoma who were taking statins – drugs that lower cholesterol in the blood – seemed to show slower progression, on average, than people who were not.

Too much LBR

A big question arose: how did the cancer cells raise cholesterol in the nuclear envelope?

The study pointed to a protein called the lamin B receptor (LBR). Think of LBR as a tool with two parts sitting in the inner nuclear membrane. One part helps attach DNA (packed with proteins) to the inner surface of the nucleus. The other part



3D structure of a melanoma cell derived by ion abrasion scanning electron microscopy. NCI/UNSPLASH

helps the cell make cholesterol.

In many melanoma samples, the researchers found that cells produced too much LBR. When LBR levels were high, the cellular cholesterol levels rose as well, and the nucleus became both more deformable and more fragile. When the team reduced the LBR levels, the nuclear envelope became tougher and less easily deformed.

Curiously, if the researchers used a version of LBR that couldn’t do its cholesterol-making job, then boosting the LBR didn’t produce the same fragile, squishy nucleus. This suggested the cholesterol-making function was central to the effect.

The team also tested what happened when they removed cholesterol directly from cell membranes: the nuclear membranes became much less fragile than in untreated cells. This fit the idea that cholesterol was changing the physical properties of the nuclear envelope.

A treatment target

The researchers then asked a bigger question: could this process start early in cancer development? If high LBR and high cholesterol appear early, then repeated small tears in the nuclear envelope could increase DNA damage over time. More DNA damage could then raise the chances of new mutations, leading to the cancer becoming more malignant.

The team engineered melanoma cells in two versions: one set with normal LBR levels and the other where LBR had been silenced (i.e. which lacked LBR). They

These findings also help explain an earlier observation: people with melanoma who were taking statins – drugs that lower cholesterol in the blood – seemed to show slower progression, on average, than people who were not

injected these cells into mice. Tumours from the control cells showed more ruptured nuclear envelopes than tumours made from LBR-silenced cells. This supported the idea that LBR could help melanoma invade and spread in a living organism.

Finally, the researchers checked patient data in the real world. In one large melanoma dataset, called TCGA-SKCM, patients whose tumours showed higher LBR expression early tended to have worse outcomes. Put together, the evidence suggested that LBR could be a useful therapeutic target for slowing cancer metastasis. “The finding that LBR-mediated cholesterol production causes nuclear envelope fragility is intriguing in the context of cancer, as high cholesterol has been associated with tumour development and immune cell invasion in melanoma,” the researchers wrote in their paper.

“Furthermore, epidemiological studies have shown that long-term statin use to decrease serum cholesterol is associated with decreased cancer progression and severity in many cancer subtypes, including melanoma.”

“Increased cholesterol synthesis driven by upregulated LBR could serve as a metabolic enhancer,” the authors continued, “increasing tumour cells’ ability to proliferate and cope with nutrient-deprived conditions. Together, our findings suggest that LBR could be a prognostic indicator in early melanoma disease progression, and could serve as a drug target to prevent metastatic dissemination of melanoma, thereby improving prognosis for patient survival.”

Curiosity-driven

Scientists first discovered LBR’s cholesterol-related role more than 25 years ago in research that had nothing to do with cancer. In the 1970s and 1980s, researchers studying fungi identified genes involved in making sterols – which are cholesterol-like molecules in fungi. In the 1990s, when scientists compared DNA sequences, they noticed that a human gene, LBR, resembled a sterol-making gene in fungi.

That raised a curious question: could the human gene replace the broken fungal gene? It could. That experiment was early evidence that LBR is an enzyme that processes sterol.

Years later, that basic biology link helped researchers connect LBR to nuclear cholesterol and the spread of cancer. It’s a clean example of how “why does this work this way?” research can eventually matter to medicine, even when no one can predict the connection in advance.

(D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist. kasbekardp@yahoo.co.in)

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



Brazilian scientists have identified a new species of giant dinosaur, whose bones are seen here, with ties to a similar animal found in Spain, reinforcing knowledge that land routes once connected parts of South America, Africa and Europe about 120 million years ago. Named *Dasosaurus tocatinensis*, the species is one of the biggest found in the South American country. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Sex bias: key to a DNA puzzle

For years, scientists noticed that modern humans carry very little Neanderthal DNA on their X chromosomes. To understand why, researchers from the University of Pennsylvania reversed the perspective and looked for early modern human DNA within ancient Neanderthal genomes.

In a study published in *Science* on February 26, they reported that interbreeding between Neanderthals and early modern humans was heavily sex-biased.

To find this, the team analysed the Altai Neanderthal genome – a female individual found in the Altai Mountains whose 1,22,000-year-old remains provide the oldest high-quality Neanderthal genome – and found a 62% excess of modern human ancestry on its X chromosome compared to its other chromosomes.

The finding allowed the team to rule out natural selection as the main cause for the missing DNA. Why? Because if biological incompatibility were the main problem, the Neanderthal X chromosome would have rejected modern human DNA. But instead it contained a surplus.

The researchers then tested whether migration patterns, such as females moving between groups, could explain the data. They found that even extreme migration models could not account for such a high 62% surplus. Instead, the



Reconstructions of a Neanderthal man named “N” (left) and woman called “Wilma” at the Neanderthal museum in Germany. AP

most likely explanation was ancestry-specific mate preference, i.e. it was concluded that interbreeding primarily involved male Neanderthals and female modern humans.

Remarkably, this bias remained consistent across different encounters separated by 200,000 years, suggesting that the social dynamics between these two groups were stable over very long periods.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Cost of treatments sanctioned under Ayushman Bharat

1.73 in ₹ lakh crore. As on February 28, 11.69 crore hospital admissions, worth ₹1.73 lakh crore, have been authorised under the Ayushman Bharat - Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana, Minister of State for Health Prataprao Jadhav told the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday. Of these, 4.40 crore admissions were in the last two financial years. PTI

Sugar production output of India in 2025-26 so far

26.21 mn tonne. India's sugar production reached 26.21 million tonne so far in the ongoing 2025-26 marketing year, up by 10.5 per cent from the year-ago period, industry body ISMA said on Tuesday. The sugar output so far has exceeded the total net production of 26.12 million tonne in the full 2024-25 marketing year (October-September). PTI

Number of deaths in suicide attacks in Nigeria's Maiduguri

23 Coordinated explosions staged by suspected suicide bombers tore through a busy market and other areas in Nigeria's northeastern city of Maiduguri, killing at least 23 people and wounding more than 100 others, police said on Tuesday. The three blasts detonated on Monday evening just after Muslims broke their fast for the Ramadan holy month, authorities said. AFP

Candidates registered in Rajasthan's employment offices

22 In lakh. The data, provided by the Directorate of Employment under the RTI Act, shows that as of January 14, a total of 22,21,317 candidates were registered as job seekers in district employment offices across the State. It was further revealed that no candidate was recruited in the government sector through the employment offices in the past five years. PTI

CPI(M) workers booked over rally against ex-party leader

500 A case was registered against around 500 CPI(M) workers in connection with a mass rally organised in Kerala, against its former leader G. Sudhakaran, who quit the party recently. The Punnapra Police registered the case, for allegedly causing traffic disruption during the march held on March 14. PTI

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On scientific collaborations in BRICS

BRICS functions as a collaborative force aimed at establishing a multipolar world system. Cooperation in science, technology and innovation has been a key agenda for the grouping and has expanded over the years to include socially relevant areas such as energy, water, health and the environment

FULL CONTEXT

Krishna Ravi Srinivas
Sneha Sinha

The BRICS grouping, comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa, is a globally significant collective defined by its substantial contributions to global GDP, scientific and technological capacity, natural resources, and total population. Since its formation, the group has evolved into a prominent international voice, representing countries that seek to challenge and provide an alternative to Western hegemony. BRICS functions as a collaborative force aimed at establishing a multipolar world system. While the group's positions on global finance and macro-economic issues are widely recognised, the depth of cooperation among member states regarding science, technology, and innovation (STI) remains less publicised.

At a time in which global scientific collaboration is increasingly dictated by geopolitical tensions, techno-nationalism, and strategic competition, often manifesting as sanctions and export controls, BRICS assumes a critical role in the global STI landscape. Through this platform, member nations coordinate their strategies, amplify their collective voice in global economic governance, and influence development finance through institutions like the New Development Bank.

These members are also vital contributors to global trade, energy production, and the supply of essential natural resources. The 2022 launch of BRICS+ signaled a move towards a more inclusive forum, fostering development and political cooperation across the Global South to reduce technological dependencies. This collaboration is now a concrete effort to build shared capacities through various framework programmes. The group's current membership has expanded to include Saudi Arabia, Egypt, the UAE, Ethiopia, Indonesia, and Iran.

Cooperation in STI

Cooperation in STI has been a part of the BRICS agenda since its early years. It was formally recognised in 2011 and later consolidated in meetings between senior officials and the BRICS Ministers of Science, Technology, and Innovation. A pivotal 2015 memorandum of understanding established STI as a core strategic pillar, providing the necessary institutional framework and operational signals for collaborative research and capacity-building. This framework has since expanded the scope of cooperation, allowing members to leverage their complementary strengths to address shared development challenges and advance frontier sciences.

The first BRICS Action Plan for Innovation Cooperation (2017-2020) tasked the Science, Technology, Innovation, and Entrepreneurship Partnership (STIEP) Working Group with implementing various programmes. These initiatives focused on entrepreneurship networks, the role of youth and women in STI, and collaborations regarding technology transfer and business incubators. Over time, BRICS has moved from early joint research calls focused on fundamental science toward prioritising innovation and technology transfer.

These priorities are formally identified in annual ministerial declarations. The BRICS Ministers of Science, Technology,



Summit dialogue: World leaders partake in the 17th annual BRICS summit in Rio de Janeiro on July 6, 2025. AP

and Innovation meet once a year to approve and sign strategic documents. Within each member country, one or two lead agencies coordinate these activities, issue calls for proposals, and prepare project lists for approval during the respective country's presidency. For example, during India's chairmanship, the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) and the Department of Biotechnology (DBT) serve as the lead agencies.

A clear emphasis on innovation-driven and technology-enabled ecosystems is evident in recent summit themes and initiatives such as iBRICS and the BRICS Technology Transfer Centre (TTC). The TTC has made notable progress in creating policy frameworks and institutional links for cross-border technology commercialisation. However, despite this progress, large-scale commercialisation of these technologies remains limited.

The focus of BRICS joint research calls has transitioned from basic science and enabling technologies to include more socially relevant areas such as energy, water, health, and the environment. The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated this shift, placing a premium on public health, vaccine research, biosecurity, and digital health. Recent calls have integrated high-performance computing (HPC), advanced materials, information and communication technology (ICT), and space-related applications. Scientific collaboration has strengthened over time, with a growing focus on artificial intelligence and data-intensive science.

While working groups reflect these shared development priorities, their progress varies across different fields. Significant progress is visible in ICT and HPC, highlighted by the establishment of the BRICS Institute of Future Networks, as well as in space cooperation following a 2021 intergovernmental agreement. Conversely, areas that require heavy infrastructure or are more exploratory, such as mega-science projects and ocean or polar research, have developed slower.

The expansion of BRICS has positioned it as a more inclusive platform for knowledge exchange and collaborative research. The 2025 Declaration on AI, elevated artificial intelligence from a sub-theme, to a central pillar of multilateral governance. This declaration outlines a vision for AI governance that is

equitable, inclusive, and development-oriented, moving the partnership towards a strategic collaboration with direct economic and societal relevance. While the 2021-24 Action Plan focused on networking and thematic frameworks, subsequent plans aim to scale projects for greater impact, focusing on biotechnology, climate tech, industrial innovation, and AI.

Under India's 2026 Presidency, with the theme 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability', the group is positioned to deepen its scientific partnerships. The goal is to leverage expanded membership to strengthen capacities and address challenges like digital divides, public health crises, and climate resilience. However, participation from new members remains uneven; among the most recent additions, only Egypt and Iran joined the call for proposals issued last December. Additionally, the China-BRICS Research Centre on New Quality Productive Forces was recently inaugurated in Beijing. This center serves as an international platform for academic exchange and technological research.

Consequences and concerns

When compared to nations like South Korea, the National Innovation Systems (NIS) of BRICS countries exhibit various strengths and weaknesses. Specifically, gross domestic expenditure on research and development (GERD) is relatively lower across the group, with the exception of China. Research suggests that the gap between BRICS nations and South Korea is wide, and member countries excluding China have significant catching up to do according to various innovation indicators. With the expansion into BRICS+, the innovation systems of new members also require assessment and strengthening. This strengthening could be a priority for BRICS over the next decade, with the potential to eventually replicate these improvements across the broader Global South.

As noted by Stanford University visiting scholar Irina Dezhina, the heterogeneity of new members in terms of both economic development and scientific capacity makes it difficult to reconcile differing interests. Consequently, BRICS+ may need to focus on catalysing new "paired links" between specific members. Comparisons to the European Union (EU)

suggest that BRICS could learn from the EU's wide variety of STI programs, as BRICS currently offers more limited options. Further, although competition for funding is intense, the total funding available remains modest.

Experts suggest that these programmes must reach a new qualitative level to effectively respond to major global challenges. Currently, however, research into STI cooperation among BRICS nations is limited, and the existing mechanism lacks a framework for regular study to provide data-driven inputs to member countries.

A way forward

While BRICS countries have achieved significant collaboration, there are questions regarding whether the current framework is sufficient for future needs. A primary concern is the lack of a permanent mechanism to manage STI cooperation. The current system, where the lead role rotates annually with the presidency, is not ideally suited for long-term requirements. BRICS could potentially model a central mechanism after the EU's Horizon Program, establishing a Secretariat to manage funds, issue calls for proposals, monitor progress, and review outcomes.

Developing a few long-term Mega-science Projects could also foster deeper cooperation. The framework for STI cooperation should eventually expand beyond just funding science and technology projects; it should promote research into the governance of STI and the impact of emerging technologies on BRICS+ nations. This would facilitate greater coherence in international treaty negotiations and help build capacity for STI governance.

In conclusion, while STI cooperation within BRICS has progressed significantly since 2015 despite various constraints, there is substantial room for improvement. Making the framework more effective, agile, and credible will enhance the group's legitimacy in the global arena. As the chair of BRICS+ in 2026, India has the opportunity to lead this transition.

(Krishna Ravi Srinivas is Adjunct Professor of Law, Director CoE in AI & Law, NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. Sneha Sinha is Consultant, Research and Information System for Developing Countries (RIS), New Delhi.)

THE GIST

BRICS has emerged as a key international voice on global finance and macro-economic issues. However, the cooperation among member states on science, technology, and innovation remains less publicised.

Scientific collaboration among BRICS nations has strengthened over time. Yet, areas that require heavy infrastructure or are more exploratory, such as mega-science projects and ocean or polar research, have developed slower.

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